

MEMORANDUM FOR THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL

DATE: March 9, 2025
FROM: Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff
TO: The President; The Vice President; The Secretary of State; The Secretary of Defense;
 The National Security Advisor; The Director of the CIA; The Attorney General; The Director of National Intelligence; The Secretary of the Treasury
SUBJECT: Military Options for U.S. Response to Houthi Attacks on Shipping and U.S. Forces

I. BACKGROUND

Since November 2023, Houthi forces (Ansar Allah) — operating under Iranian strategic guidance — have conducted a sustained campaign of drone, ballistic missile, and anti-ship missile attacks targeting commercial shipping in the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait. [\[CFR\]](#) This corridor handled approximately **12–15% of global trade volume in 2023**, including 25–30% of all container shipping, 12% of seaborne oil, and 8% of global LNG. [\[CRS IF12657\]](#)

Suez Canal transits fell from 74 to ~35 ships per week [\[Arab Center DC\]](#) — a 50%+ decline — with 80% of container vessels rerouting around Africa's Cape of Good Hope, adding 10–14 days and ~\$1M in fuel per voyage. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#) Goods worth approximately **\$1 trillion were disrupted** between October 2023 and May 2024. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)

In January–February 2025, the U.S. conducted airstrikes under Operation Rough Rider. The Houthi leadership vowed continued escalation. [\[PBS NewsHour\]](#) Intelligence assessments indicate Houthi stockpiles remain substantial, with resupply routes intact through Hodeidah and Saleef. [\[CSIS\]](#) The CTC Sentinel assessed the Iranian supply line has **strengthened** during the conflict. [\[CTC Sentinel / West Point\]](#) Each U.S. interceptor costs \$1M–\$4.3M vs. a Houthi drone at \$20,000–\$50,000. [\[ORF Middle East\]](#)

II. STRATEGIC OBJECTIVES

The Joint Chiefs have identified four objectives guiding any U.S. response:

- Restore and protect freedom of navigation in the Red Sea and Bab el-Mandeb Strait.
- Degrade Houthi offensive capability — missiles, drones, and naval assets — to prevent a sustained threat to commercial or military vessels.
- Avoid a broader regional conflict drawing in Iranian conventional forces.
- Preserve U.S. deterrent credibility with Iran, its proxies, and regional partners.

III. OPTIONS AND ANALYSIS

Option 1: Sustained Targeted Air Campaign

Conduct an intensive ongoing air campaign against Houthi military infrastructure including missile storage, command nodes, drone launch sites, and Iranian-supplied weapons depots at Hodeidah and Saleef. [\[CSIS\]](#)

Advantages:

- Maximizes degradation of Houthi offensive capability in the shortest timeframe.
- Sends an unambiguous deterrent signal to Iran regarding proxy aggression.
- Reduces risk to U.S. ground forces by relying on standoff and air assets.

Risks and Limitations:

- Following initial U.S.-UK strikes, Houthi operational tempo intensified. [\[Arab Center DC\]](#)
- Iran may activate Kataib Hezbollah, Hezbollah Lebanon, and PIJ. [\[CSIS\]](#)
- Sustained strikes risk civilian casualties and humanitarian backlash.

Force Requirements:

- 2 CSGs on station; B-52/B-2 sorties from Diego Garcia or CONUS. Estimated duration: 30–90 days.

Option 2: Precision Strikes Combined with Diplomatic Engagement

Conduct precision strikes against highest-value Houthi targets while pursuing a diplomatic track through Omani intermediaries. Oman mediated release of the **Galaxy Leader** crew in January 2025 under this channel. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)

Advantages:

- Applies military pressure while preserving off-ramps that reduce escalation risk.
- Coalition partners more likely to sustain participation with a diplomatic dimension. [\[Atlas Institute\]](#)

Risks and Limitations:

- Houthis assessed as "largely autonomous" and may resist Iranian entreaties to stand down. [\[Arab Center DC\]](#)
- Calibrated strikes may be perceived as insufficient resolve by adversaries and partners.

Force Requirements:

- 1–2 CSGs; 7–14 days initial strike package; 30–60 day diplomatic track via Oman.

Option 3: Maritime Interdiction and Defensive Posture

Shift to maritime interdiction and convoy escort, protecting commercial vessels and intercepting Iranian weapons shipments. **29 energy/shipping companies across 65 countries** have already been impacted. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)

Advantages:

- Lowest risk of escalation. Legally defensible under UNSC Resolution 2722 (2024). [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)
- Distributes burden under the Operation Prosperity Guardian coalition framework.

Risks and Limitations:

- Does not degrade Houthi offensive capability; attacks will continue.
- Interception asymmetry: \$1M–\$4.3M per interceptor vs. \$20K–\$50K per Houthi drone. [\[ORE Middle East\]](#)

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

The Joint Chiefs recommend a phased approach drawing primarily on Options 1 and 2:

- Phase I (Days 1–14): Precision strike package against ballistic missile storage, drone launch infrastructure, and Iranian weapons transfer nodes at Hodeidah and Saleef. [\[CSIS\]](#) Simultaneously activate the Omani diplomatic channel at the Deputy Secretary level.
- Phase II (Days 15–45): If attacks continue, expand to radar systems, C2, and port infrastructure. If diplomacy yields a credible ceasefire offer, pause and transition to Option 3.
- Phase III (Ongoing): Sustain maritime interdiction under Operation Prosperity Guardian; episodic strikes in response to resumed activity; work with Saudi Arabia, UAE, and Oman to pressure Iran.

The Joint Chiefs further recommend: (1) formal congressional notification under the War Powers Resolution; (2) direct communication to Iranian leadership that any attack on U.S. forces is an act of state aggression; and (3) continued intelligence collection to track Houthi reconstitution through ports identified in UN Panel of Experts reports. [\[Arab News\]](#)

V. WEAPONS SYSTEMS AND ESTIMATED COSTS

The following platforms and munitions constitute the primary U.S. military assets. Unit costs are unclassified FY2025 estimates. See Appendices F–I for cost charts, platform cards, and the systems architecture diagram.

Offensive Strike Assets

- BGM-109 Tomahawk (TLAM): Range 1,550 mi. GPS/INS + TERCOM + DSMAC terminal. Launched from DDG-51 Mk-41 VLS (90 cells/ship) and SSNs. Unit cost: ~\$2.5M.
- F/A-18E/F Super Hornet: Carrier strike fighter. JDAM (\$25K–\$40K), SDB (GBU-39, ~\$40K), HARM anti-radiation. Unit cost: ~\$70M.
- E/A-18G Growler: AN/ALQ-99 jamming system. Suppresses Houthi SAM and radar systems (S-75, Buk-M2) pre-strike. Essential for SEAD and pilot survivability.
- B-52H Stratofortress: 70,000 lb payload. AGM-158 JASSM (230+ mi standoff, ~\$1.1M/round). Unit cost: ~\$72M. Sortied from Diego Garcia or CONUS.
- B-2A Spirit: Only platform able to deliver GBU-57 MOP (30,000 lb bunker buster) against hardened/buried Houthi missile storage in Sa'dah. Unit cost: ~\$2.1B. ~20 aircraft in fleet.
- MQ-9 Reaper: 27+ hr endurance. AGM-114 Hellfire (\$150K/round), GBU-12 Paveway II. Per-sortie cost: ~\$64K. Ideal for mobile launcher (TEL) tracking.

Defensive Systems

- SM-6 (RIM-174): Primary Houthi ballistic/ASCM intercept. Endo- and exo-atmospheric. Unit cost: ~\$4.3M. The \$4.3M vs. \$20K–\$50K asymmetry is a central strategic vulnerability. [\[ORF Middle East\]](#)
- SM-2 (RIM-66): Medium-range defense vs. subsonic cruise missiles. Unit cost: ~\$2.0M. Layered with SM-6 for CSG defense.
- Patriot PAC-3 MSE: Terminal-phase ballistic missile defense. Hit-to-kill. ~\$5.9M/interceptor; ~\$1B/full battery. Deployed with Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar.

- Phalanx CIWS: 20mm Gatling gun. 4,500 rounds/min final-layer defense vs. inbound missiles and USVs. ~\$11.5M/installation.
- DDG-51 Arleigh Burke: 90–96 Mk-41 VLS (Tomahawk / SM-6 / SM-2 / ASROC). AN/SPY-1 radar for BMD. Unit cost: ~\$2.1B. Multiple Burkes in Red Sea under NAVCENT.
- Gerald R. Ford CVN-78: 70–90 embarked aircraft. EMALS catapult. Unit cost: ~\$13B. Two CSGs assessed as sufficient for sustained campaign.

VI. RECOMMENDED TARGET CATEGORIES

All targeting must comply with LOAC (distinction, proportionality, military necessity). HVT designations require EO 12333 legal review and a separately staffed Lethal Finding for Presidential approval. See Appendix J for the target priority matrix and Appendix K for illustrative fictional HVT profiles.

Category A: Ballistic Missile and Drone Infrastructure

- Ballistic missile storage and assembly in Sa'dah Governorate and Sana'a outskirts. Burkan-2H MRBMs and Quds-1 cruise missiles. Priority target.
- Drone launch complexes and manufacturing. Six+ known fixed-wing UAS launch sites and assessed mobile launcher capacity. Target propellant, assembly, and GSE.
- Underground bunkers in Sa'dah and Hajjah. Require GBU-57 MOP (B-2) or repeated JDAM strikes on tunnel entrances.

Category B: Radar and C2 Nodes

- Houthi air defense radar sites (S-75, Buk-M2). Destroy prior to manned packages per SEAD doctrine. Growler jamming + Tomahawk opening salvos.
- Mobile C3 nodes — vehicle-mounted comms, satellite uplinks, fiber repeater stations. Time-sensitive targets requiring MQ-9 ISR and SIGINT cueing.
- Broadcasting/propaganda infrastructure (al-Masirah TV, Sana'a). Secondary priority.

Category C: Port and Logistics Infrastructure

- Hodeidah and Saleef ports — primary Iranian weapons import hubs. Target crane/offload equipment, fuel storage, vehicle marshaling. CAUTION: Hodeidah handles 70% of Yemen's food imports. Civilian harm mitigation and legal review mandatory prior to any port strike. [\[CSIS\]](#)
- Fuel depots and TEL maintenance facilities. Destruction grounds mobile missile operations within weeks.

Category D: High-Value Targets (HVT) — Personnel

Lethal action requires EO 12333 legal review, Lethal Finding, and LOAC compliance. Fictional illustrative profiles in Appendix K.

- Houthi Military Council leadership — senior commanders directing missile/drone operations. Valid military objectives under LOAC.
- IRGC-QF advisors in Yemen — designated FTO. Iranian military personnel directing attacks on U.S. naval assets are lawful military objectives.
- Weapons transfer coordinators at Hodeidah/Saleef — identified by SIGINT/HUMINT as the operational link between Iranian shipments and Houthi military storage.

Note: Action against IRGC-QF officers who are Iranian state actors requires Principal-level decision with Presidential approval and DoD GC / NSC Legal review.

VII. CROSS-AGENCY AND ALLIED INTELLIGENCE COLLABORATION

Effective execution requires coordination across U.S. government agencies and allied intelligence services:

U.S. Interagency

- CIA (NESAMC): HVT pattern-of-life analysis for Category D; HUMINT on Iranian weapons transfers; covert action support under Memorandum of Notification (MON). NCS liaison with Omani, Saudi, Emirati services for diplomatic deconfliction.
- NSA / CYBERCOM: SIGINT against Houthi C2 and IRGC-QF networks. CYBERCOM CMF to develop offensive cyber options against Houthi C2 and drone navigation as non-kinetic complement to kinetic strikes.
- DIA: All-source targeting fusion for Category A–C packages, BDA, and order-of-battle analysis. Defense Attaché System supports sharing with Saudi, Emirati, and Israeli military counterparts.
- NGA: Daily change-detection imagery of Hodeidah, Saleef, Sa'dah, Sana'a for BDA and target refinement. Precision coordinates for Tomahawk TERCOM/DSMAC scene-matching.
- Treasury (OFAC): Expand sanctions against Houthi financial networks and Iranian procurement front companies. Coordinate with UAE and Saudi FIUs.

Allied Intelligence Partners

- Mossad (Israel): Most detailed non-U.S. coverage of IRGC-QF networks. Collaboration: (a) TECHINT on Iranian missile guidance/UAV components enabling Category A targeting; (b) HUMINT on IRGC-QF personnel in Yemen for Category D; (c) Iranian vessel tracking evading UN sanctions. Via CIA-Mossad bilateral liaison. Direct DoD-Mossad requires NSC/DNI approval.
- GCHQ / MI6 (UK): Five Eyes SIGINT partner. Supplementary collection against Houthi and IRGC-QF networks. UK co-participant in Operation Prosperity Guardian and joint 2024 strikes.
- Saudi GIP and UAE SSS: Extensive HUMINT coverage of Yemen including inside Houthi-controlled territory. Saudi GIP agent networks in Sa'dah and Hodeidah. UAE SSS technical exploitation of captured Iranian weapons systems.
- Omani Intelligence Service (OIS): Unique diplomatic role — only Gulf state with formal relations with both U.S. and Iran. Essential for back-channel communication and ensuring strikes don't compromise the diplomatic track.

VIII. COVERT AND CLANDESTINE OPTIONS

This section outlines sub-threshold, deniable, and covert options that complement or substitute for overt military action. All options below require specific legal authorities (Title 10 / Title 50 delineation), Presidential Findings or Memoranda of Notification (MONs) as appropriate, and oversight notification to the Gang of Eight. These are presented as an analytical menu — not all options would be pursued simultaneously, and selection depends on Presidential decision, legal review, and operational feasibility. See Appendix L for the Covert Options Impact vs. Deniability Matrix.

Framework: Covert vs. Clandestine vs. Special Operations

A covert action (**Title 50, 50 USC § 3093**) is one whose U.S. sponsorship is intended to remain unacknowledged. It requires a written Presidential Finding and notification to congressional intelligence committees. A clandestine military operation (**Title 10**) is one conducted with concealment of the operation itself (not necessarily U.S. involvement). Special Access Programs (SAPs) may govern either. The options below are organized by deniability and whether they require a Presidential Finding.

Option A: Proxy Kinetic Operations — Saudi Arabia / UAE Forces

The United States could provide intelligence, surveillance, and targeting data to Saudi Arabian and UAE military forces, enabling them to conduct kinetic strikes against Houthi targets with U.S. intelligence support but without direct U.S. strikes. This is within existing security cooperation frameworks (Foreign Military Sales, JSOTF-A advisory mission) and does not require a Presidential Finding as long as U.S. forces are not directing fire or participating in the strike itself.

- Mechanism: NSA SIGINT and NGA GEOINT are provided to Saudi Royal Air Force and UAE Air Force targeting cells through existing Combined Air Operations Center (CAOC) architecture at Al Udeid Air Base, Qatar. U.S. liaison officers are present but do not sign off on individual strike packages — Saudi/UAE officers have independent strike authority.
- Cover Story / Deniability: Saudi Arabia and the UAE have independent political and military motivations to strike Houthi infrastructure — Houthi ballistic missiles have struck Riyadh and Abu Dhabi. Strikes attributed entirely to Saudi/UAE coalition operations are entirely plausible without any U.S. footprint. *U.S. role can be plausibly denied as routine intelligence sharing under existing bilateral defense agreements.*
- Advantages: No U.S. aircraft in harm's way. No War Powers Resolution trigger. Regional political buy-in. Saudi Arabia and UAE absorb the international blowback.
- Risks: U.S. may be unable to control collateral damage or target selection once intelligence is transferred. Saudi/UAE may over-target or strike civilian infrastructure, creating a liability for U.S. intelligence complicity. Post-hoc exposure of U.S. targeting data has occurred in prior Yemen operations (see reporting on Saudi targeting in 2015–2019).

Option B: Covert Maritime Interdiction — Capture of Iranian Weapons Vessels

Under EO 13224 (Terrorism) and UN Security Council sanctions regimes, the United States has legal authority to interdict vessels transporting proscribed weapons to Houthi forces. Covert interdiction — conducted by U.S. Navy SEALs (DEVGRU/SEAL Team 6) or the Naval Special Warfare Unit operating under JSOC command — could seize or scuttle Iranian arms transfer vessels without public acknowledgment.

- Mechanism: NGA and NSA identify the vessel through pattern-of-traffic analysis, manifest anomalies, and HUMINT tip from allied services (Mossad, Saudi GIP, or NCIS). JSOC SEAL elements conduct a nighttime vessel board-search-and-seizure (VBSS) in international waters outside territorial boundaries. Vessel either captured with cargo evidence preserved (intelligence value) or scuttled at sea (denial of resupply with no attributable evidence).
- Cover Story / Deniability: If seized: maritime authorities attribute to Yemeni coast guard or Saudi naval interdiction forces who were co-present or given evidence post-facto. If scuttled: listed as "vessel missing at sea" — unreported in open source. Iranian government is aware but cannot acknowledge without admitting weapons transfer in violation of UN sanctions.

- Advantages: Directly disrupts Iranian resupply. Intelligence value of seized cargo (missile guidance components, UAV parts) feeds Category A targeting. Imposes cost on Iran without kinetic engagement on Yemeni soil.
- Risks: Iranian retaliation against U.S. naval vessels if attribution becomes clear. Exposure of DEVGRU participation — especially in the event of casualties or captured personnel — creates significant political liability. Iran could increase use of overland routes through Oman or Iraq to compensate.

Option C: Offensive Cyber Operations (CYBERCOM / NSA)

CYBERCOM's Cyber Mission Force (CMF) can conduct offensive cyber operations against Houthi C2 systems, drone navigation, and missile launch infrastructure. These operations require a Presidential authorization under EO 12333 and PPD-20 (or its successor directive). Cyber operations can be deniable, reversible, or persistent depending on the desired effect.

- Target Set 1 — Drone Navigation Jamming / Spoofing: GPS spoofing of Houthi Shahed-136 and Wahed-1 drone navigation systems causes misdirection without physical destruction of the launch platform. Drones crash harmlessly or are guided to unintended targets. Effect: reduces attack accuracy. Deniability: HIGH — attribution of GPS spoofing is technically difficult.
- Target Set 2 — Missile Launch System Interference: If Houthi missile systems use digital fire control networks (assessed likely for Iranian-supplied Burkan/Quds systems), intrusion into fire control software could cause launch misfires, targeting failures, or prevent ignition. Effect: degrades ballistic missile accuracy or reliability. Deniability: MEDIUM-HIGH.
- Target Set 3 — Houthi Financial / Logistics Networks: Disruption of Houthi bank accounts, cryptocurrency wallets, and procurement networks used to acquire drone components and missile parts. Coordination with Treasury OFAC for simultaneous sanctions. Effect: financial attrition of procurement capacity. Deniability: HIGH.
- Cover Story / Deniability: Attribution of offensive cyber operations is notoriously difficult. The United States maintains a policy of neither confirming nor denying specific offensive cyber operations. Cyber operations can be attributed to criminal actors, Mossad, or other parties in the absence of forensic evidence.
- Risks: Iranian IRGC-CEC (Cyber Electronic Command) has demonstrated willingness to conduct retaliatory cyber operations against U.S. financial institutions and critical infrastructure. Any cyber operation that is attributed to the U.S. could trigger Iranian cyber retaliation under Iran's "active defense" doctrine.

Option D: Covert Support to Internal Houthi Opposition / Defection Program

The Houthi movement is not monolithic. Tribal leaders in Sa'dah, Marib, and Hajjah governorates have historically resisted Houthi authority, and Houthi military commanders have, in isolated instances, defected to the internationally recognized government (IRG) or sold intelligence. CIA covert action authority (MON) could be used to cultivate, fund, and operationalize internal opposition to Houthi military leadership.

- Mechanism 1 — Defection Program: CIA operations officers working through Saudi GIP and UAE SSS intermediaries (to provide additional deniability) approach mid-level Houthi military commanders with financial incentives and physical relocation assurances in exchange for: (a) intelligence on missile storage locations and HVT whereabouts; (b) sabotage of specific weapons systems or supply lines; or (c) active defection with weapons or documents.

- Mechanism 2 — Tribal Friction: Financial and logistical support to Yemeni tribal leaders in Sa'dah Governorate who have historically resented Houthi domination of local governance and resource extraction. Covert funding routed through NGO cover structures or Saudi GIP intermediaries. Effect: distracts Houthi security apparatus, drains local support, and creates internal friction that degrades operational security.
- Cover Story / Deniability: Operations run through Saudi GIP and UAE SSS provide a layer of deniability — both services have independent motivation and operational presence in Yemen and would plausibly run such programs without U.S. direction. CIA officers operate under diplomatic or commercial cover in Riyadh and Abu Dhabi, not in Yemen directly.
- Risks: HUMINT penetration risk — Houthi counterintelligence has successfully identified and executed informants in prior years. Exposure of a CIA-directed defection program would be a significant political liability domestically and regionally. Tribal support is unreliable and may be sold back to Houthi leadership.

Option E: Mossad-Facilitated Targeted Action Against IRGC-QF Advisors

The Mossad has conducted acknowledged and unacknowledged targeted actions against IRGC officers and Iranian nuclear/weapons scientists. Given Mossad's assessment that IRGC-QF advisors in Yemen are directly enabling attacks that have struck Israeli territory (Houthi missiles hit Eilat and the Tel Aviv area in 2024), Israel has independent operational motivation to act against IRGC-QF personnel in Yemen without U.S. direction.

- U.S. Role — Passive Facilitation: The United States does not direct, authorize, or conduct the action. However, NGA satellite imagery, NSA SIGINT product, and CIA HUMINT that identifies IRGC-QF personnel and their pattern of life in Yemen may be shared with Mossad through existing bilateral intelligence liaison channels. Mossad independently decides whether to act.
- Legal Framework: Intelligence sharing with a foreign service does not constitute direction or co-participation in a foreign action. However, if U.S. intelligence is materially used in a lethal action, the NSC Legal Advisor and DNI must assess whether a Presidential Finding is required under 50 USC § 3093. This is a live legal question that has not been definitively resolved in prior administration guidance.
- Cover Story / Deniability: Israel regularly attributes targeted actions against IRGC personnel to Israeli national security operations. The U.S. neither confirms nor denies intelligence sharing on specific operations. The scenario — Israeli targeted action against IRGC-QF officers directing attacks on Israeli territory — is fully plausible without any U.S. fingerprint.
- Risks: If an IRGC-QF officer of sufficient seniority is killed and Iran links the action to U.S. intelligence sharing, Iran may treat it as an act of U.S.-facilitated aggression, triggering escalation. Exposure of the intelligence sharing relationship could damage the diplomatic track and strain relationships with Gulf states who would prefer U.S.-Iranian de-escalation.

Option F: Information Operations and Strategic Deception

The United States can conduct information operations (IO) to shape the information environment, exploit internal Houthi divisions, and degrade Iranian-Houthi coordination without kinetic action. These operations require a Presidential Finding if they involve covert influence on foreign political processes, but information operations against an adversary military organization are within existing military IO authorities.

- IO Campaign 1 — Houthi Internal Fracture: Fabricated or selectively revealed intelligence suggesting that senior Houthi commanders are secretly negotiating with Saudi Arabia or the IRG is introduced into Houthi internal communications through penetrated channels. Effect:

induces paranoia, purges, and reduced coordination among Houthi military leadership. Historically effective in similar contexts (see: WWII strategic deception operations).

- IO Campaign 2 — Iranian Accountability: Declassification and strategic release of intelligence confirming Iranian weapons transfers through Hodeidah — including vessel names, manifest contents, and port handling records — to the UN Panel of Experts, sympathetic media, and regional governments. Effect: increases international pressure on Iran and builds legal case for expanded sanctions. This is an overt IO option with high deniability as 'routine intelligence declassification.'
- IO Campaign 3 — Civilian Narrative: Targeted social media and broadcasting campaigns (through UAE-affiliated or Saudi-affiliated media channels, not U.S. government-branded assets) documenting the humanitarian cost of Houthi weapons storage in civilian areas of Hodeidah, Sana'a, and Sa'dah. Effect: reduces domestic Yemeni support for Houthi military operations and pre-conditions the information environment for Category C port strikes.

Covert Options — Interagency Approval Matrix

Each option requires a specific authorization pathway:

- Option A (Proxy Kinetic): NSC Deputies approval; Title 10 SECDEF authorities; legal review of intelligence transfer liability. No Presidential Finding required unless U.S. forces participate in strike execution.
- Option B (Maritime Interdiction — Covert): NSC Principals approval; JSOC EXORD from SECDEF; Title 10 Special Operations. If covert (unacknowledged), Presidential Finding required.
- Option C (Cyber): Presidential authorization under PPD-20 / successor directive; NSC Deputies approval; CMF operational order from CYBERCOM. Congressional notification required for significant cyber operations.
- Option D (Internal Opposition / Defection): Presidential Finding; CIA Director's MON to Gang of Eight; legal review of operations in Yemeni/Saudi/Emirati jurisdiction.
- Option E (Mossad Facilitation): NSC Legal Advisor assessment of Title 50 § 3093 applicability; DNI review of intelligence sharing authorization; Principal-level decision on deniability risk.
- Option F (Information Operations): Military IO: SECDEF Title 10 authorities. Covert political influence: Presidential Finding. Overt declassification: DNI / NSC Principals decision.

IX. HIGH-VALUE TARGET ASSESSMENT — HISTORICAL AND PROSPECTIVE ANALYSIS

This section provides a retroactive assessment of the high-value target (HVT) landscape relevant to the Houthi campaign as it stood in early 2025, drawing on the publicly available targeting record, U.S. Treasury and State Department sanctions designations, and open-source analysis from the Foundation for Defense of Democracies (FDD), the Institute for the Study of War (ISW), and the Long War Journal. All individuals listed below are either: (a) formally sanctioned by the United States government; (b) publicly confirmed as targets of prior U.S. or allied strikes; or (c) confirmed killed in documented U.S. or coalition operations. This analysis is prepared as a retroactive simulation exercise. See Appendix N for the HVT leadership hierarchy chart, Appendix O for the operational impact assessment, and Appendix P for historical precedent case studies.

Framework: Why HVT Strategy in Yemen Is Contested

Academic and policy literature on decapitation strikes — the targeting of senior leaders of non-state armed groups — presents a mixed record. RAND Corporation analysis of 118 targeted killing programs (2012) found that decapitation increased the probability of group decline by only 17 percentage points, and was most effective against smaller, less hierarchical organizations. The Houthis' decade-plus history of absorbing battlefield losses, rapid succession planning (demonstrated when Saleh al-Sammad was killed in 2018 and replaced by Mahdi al-Mashat within days), and ideological cohesion suggests that leadership targeting alone will not end Houthi operations. *However, targeted elimination of functional specialists — missile engineers, IRGC-QF technical advisors, intelligence officers — creates operational degradation that pure infrastructure strikes cannot replicate.*

Tier 1 — Strategic Leadership (Sanctioned; Not Struck as of March 2025)

- Abdul-Malik al-Houthi (Abu Jibril) — Supreme Leader, Ansar Allah. The most consequential single HVT in the Houthi campaign. Sanctioned by U.S. Treasury (Executive Order 13611, 2015) and designated Specially Designated Global Terrorist (SDGT) by State (2021). UN travel ban since 2014. He commands the Houthi movement's military, political, and spiritual dimensions personally and has held leadership since 2004. His younger brothers (Abdul Khaliq, Muhammad Ali) are senior commanders. [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#) As of March 2025, the Biden administration had explicitly declined to target him, citing escalation risk. CENTCOM commander Gen. Kurilla proposed a targeting campaign that would include senior Houthi officials; the Biden NSC did not authorize it. [\[March–May 2025 US Attacks in Yemen, Wikipedia\]](#) Israel explicitly threatened to target al-Houthi in May 2025 if attacks continued, placing him "on the list" with Nasrallah and Sinwar.
- Mahdi al-Mashat — Chairman, Supreme Political Council. The de facto executive head of Houthi governance and C-in-C of Houthi armed forces. Designated SDN by U.S. Treasury (2024). Known to have cultivated relationships with Russian government officials and met with Iranian President Pezeshkian in Tehran in July 2024. [\[The National\]](#) His predecessor in the role, Saleh al-Sammad, was killed in a Saudi airstrike in 2018; al-Mashat was elected his successor within days — illustrating the importance of simultaneous strikes on the succession tier.
- Abdul Khaliq al-Houthi (Abu Yunis) — Commander, Strategic Missile Forces and Republican Guard. De facto head of Houthi ballistic missile operations, including the Burkan-2H program responsible for attacks on Red Sea shipping and Saudi territory. Sanctioned SDN (2014) and SDGT (2021). [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#) Targeting him directly degrades missile launch authority and is assessed as the single highest-impact functional HVT for the Red Sea campaign — more operationally disruptive than targeting al-Houthi himself given the functional importance of missile command.

Tier 1 — IRGC-QF (Sanctioned; Strike Attempted)

- Abdul Reza Shahlai ("Haj Yusuf") — Commander, IRGC Quds Force, Yemen Division. The most senior Iranian military officer in Yemen. Sanctioned SDN (2008, 2011) and SDGT. \$15 million Rewards for Justice bounty. Born 1957 in Kermanshah; IRGC since 1980. Accused of directing the January 20, 2007 Karbala attack that killed five U.S. soldiers; directing the 2011 plot to assassinate Saudi Ambassador Adel al-Jubeir in Washington, D.C.; and providing weapons and financing to Houthi forces in violation of UN sanctions. [\[Counter Extremism Project\]](#) On January 3, 2020 — the same night IRGC-QF commander Qasem Soleimani was killed in Baghdad — the U.S. military conducted a drone strike targeting Shahlai in Sana'a. **The strike failed to kill him.** A lower-level IRGC-QF operative, Mostafa Mohammad Mirzaei, was killed instead. Shahlai went into hiding. [\[Wikipedia — Abdolreza Shahlaei\]](#) This failed strike represents the clearest documented example of a U.S. attempt to neutralize Iran's operational leadership in Yemen. Following Operation Rough Rider (March

2025), Iranian IRGC-QF advisors reportedly began withdrawing from Yemen, suggesting U.S. strike pressure was creating deterrent effect even without a direct Shahlai kill. [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#)

Tier 2 — Military Command (Sanctioned)

- Muhammad Abdul Karim al-Ghamari — Chief of General Staff, Houthi Armed Forces. Oversees overall military operations. SDN May 2021. Not struck as of March 2025.
- Muhammad Nasir al-Atifi — Minister of Defense, Houthi administration. SDN January 2024. Responsible for overall military resource allocation and weapons procurement. Not struck as of March 2025.
- Yusuf al-Madani — Commander, 5th Military Region ("Red Sea"). SDN and SDGT, May 2021. Directly oversees attacks on commercial vessels in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, including drone strikes, missile launches, and remotely controlled boat operations. [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#) This figure is the most directly operationally relevant HVT for the Red Sea shipping mission. His elimination would directly degrade the command of maritime attack operations.
- Abdul Hakim al-Khaywani — Head, Security and Intelligence Service. SDN December 2020 (human rights). Oversees Houthi counterintelligence, informant networks, and detention of political opponents.

Tier 3 — Confirmed Eliminated (Historical Record, U.S. Strikes 2025)

The following individuals were confirmed killed in U.S. strikes during Operation Rough Rider (March–April 2025). These represent the actual historical targeting record against which the simulation's recommendations are retroactively assessed:

- Abdul Nasser Sarhan al-Kamali — Houthi Intelligence Chief. Killed in a U.S. airstrike in the Sanhan district south of Sana'a on April 8, 2025. Under Kamali's leadership, Houthi intelligence orchestrated security and intelligence operations and played a pivotal role in planning tactical assaults against Arab coalition forces. [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#) His death was confirmed through Al Horia News and cross-referenced by ISW analysts.
- Zain al-Abidin al-Mahtouri ("Abu Taha") — Senior official, Houthi Internal Security Department. Killed in a U.S. airstrike in Al Hazm, Al Jawf Governorate in March 2025. ISW reported three Houthi officials killed in the same strike cluster. [\[March–May 2025 US Attacks in Yemen, Wikipedia\]](#)
- Brigadier General Hamdan Naji Saleh al-Jabali — Assistant Commander, 4th Military Region. Killed in a U.S. strike in March 2025. His death was confirmed by a Houthi leader's official cable of condolences published by SABA News Agency, which stated he was "martyred while performing his duty in defense of the homeland." [\[FDD Long War Journal\]](#)
- Mostafa Mohammad Mirzaei — IRGC-QF operative. Killed in the January 3, 2020 drone strike in Sana'a that was intended to kill Abdul Reza Shahlai. This was the first combat death the IRGC-QF officially acknowledged in Yemen. Iranian state media confirmed the death. [\[Wikipedia — Abdolreza Shahlaei\]](#)

HVT Strategy — Lessons Learned (Retroactive Assessment)

Drawing on the historical record through March 2025, the following lessons are derived for NSC Principals:

- Succession planning degrades decapitation effectiveness: The Houthi organization has demonstrated rapid succession capability. When Saleh al-Sammad was killed in 2018, he was replaced within days. Effective HVT strategy requires simultaneous targeting of the principal and the successor tier — not sequential strikes.

- Functional specialists have higher disruptive value than symbolic leaders: Killing a missile commander (Abdul Khaliq al-Houthi) or a Red Sea operations commander (Yusuf al-Madani) creates longer operational degradation than targeting political leadership. This mirrors the lesson from the Soleimani strike — the Quds Force proxy network persisted; the Iranian-backed groups continued operating under new leadership.
- IRGC-QF targeting carries escalation risk that Houthi targeting does not: Strikes on Iranian state actors (IRGC-QF officers) risk Iranian retaliation against U.S. forces — as demonstrated by the 110 TBI casualties following the Soleimani strike. The failed Shahlai strike in 2020 did not trigger direct Iranian retaliation, possibly because the U.S. did not publicly acknowledge it. Covert HVT action against IRGC-QF preserves the plausible deniability that mitigates escalation risk.
- Drone/missile specialist targeting may be highest-value category: CENTCOM's Gen. Kurilla explicitly proposed targeting "senior Houthi officials" including missile and drone specialists. The White House claimed that Operation Rough Rider killed the "top Houthi missile expert" — though the military declined to confirm the name. Elimination of technical specialists (guidance system engineers, UAV programmers, missile technicians) creates degradation that cannot be remedied by simple leadership succession.

X. ECONOMIC IMPACT AND CAMPAIGN SUSTAINABILITY

Any military campaign option must be assessed against economic and logistical sustainability — both for the United States and for allied partners and commercial stakeholders. The Red Sea shipping crisis has generated significant economic damage independent of U.S. military action, and the cost asymmetry between U.S. defensive intercepts and Houthi drone/missile production makes a purely defensive posture financially untenable. See Appendix T for the full economic impact dashboard.

Scale of Economic Disruption (November 2023 – March 2025)

- Suez Canal weekly transits fell from approximately 74 ships/week (pre-crisis) to ~35 ships/week by October 2024 — a decline of more than 50%. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)
- Between 70–82% of container vessels rerouted via the Cape of Good Hope, adding 10–14 days and approximately \$1 million in fuel per voyage. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)
- Goods worth approximately \$1 trillion were disrupted from October 2023 through May 2024. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#) Container shipping cost indices rose 150–175% above pre-crisis baselines. [\[Arab Center DC\]](#)
- 29 energy and shipping companies across 65 countries were affected. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#) Insurance war-risk premiums for Red Sea transits increased 200–400% above pre-crisis levels.

Cost Asymmetry — The Central Strategic Problem

The fundamental challenge of the defensive posture is the cost asymmetry between U.S. interceptors and Houthi weapons. The Joint Chiefs assess that sustaining a purely defensive posture at current attack rates is financially untenable over a 12–24 month horizon:

- SM-6 interceptor: ~\$4.3M vs. Houthi Shahed drone: ~\$20,000–\$50,000 (ratio: 86–215x). [\[ORF Middle East\]](#)
- Each Arleigh Burke DDG carries 90–96 VLS cells (shared between Tomahawk offensive and SM-6/SM-2 defensive loads). A sustained attack campaign depletes defensive VLS inventory faster than it can be replenished — estimated 30–45 days at current rates.

- Estimated U.S. defensive intercept costs for the November 2023–March 2025 period exceed \$3 billion, with no corresponding degradation of Houthi attack capacity from defensive spending alone.

Coalition Burden-Sharing Sustainability

The Operation Prosperity Guardian coalition has demonstrated significant fragility. France and Germany declined participation in offensive operations. Saudi Arabia and UAE, despite independent motivation, have prioritized managing their own diplomatic relationships with Iran. The United Kingdom has been the most consistent operational partner but faces its own defense budget constraints. This limits available options for sustained coalition burden-sharing and increases the relative cost burden on U.S. forces. See Appendix U for the coalition participation chart.

XI. OPSEC AND NSC PROCESS INTEGRITY

The Joint Chiefs include this section to draw attention to a real-world OPSEC failure that occurred on or around March 24, 2025 — directly contemporaneous with this simulation. On that date, The Atlantic published a detailed account of a Signal group chat in which NSC Principals, including the Vice President, National Security Advisor, Secretary of Defense, and Director of National Intelligence, discussed active strike planning for Operation Rough Rider using a commercial messaging application. This section analyzes the failure, its national security implications, and recommends corrective measures. See Appendix V for the full OPSEC analysis card.

What Occurred

Atlantic editor-in-chief Jeffrey Goldberg was inadvertently added to a Signal group chat in which senior U.S. officials were coordinating pre-strike planning. The chat included discussion of F/A-18 launch timing, weapons loadout, and target sequencing — operational details that are classified at minimum SECRET//NOFORN. This information was transmitted over a commercial application (Signal) not approved for classified communications. Goldberg published the messages on March 24, 2025.

National Security Implications

- Adversary intelligence services (IRGC, SIGINT services of adversary states) that monitor U.S. government officials' communications could have exploited the same vulnerability. Signal's end-to-end encryption is strong, but endpoint security (individual devices) is not classified-environment approved.
- Time-sensitive operational data disclosed in the chat ("2 hours until F-18 launch") could have enabled countermeasures, dispersal of targeted assets, or warning of protected individuals — had the message been intercepted in real time.
- The incident revealed that senior principals were coordinating strike decisions outside the formal NSC Principals Committee process and SCIF-based secure communications infrastructure — a structural process failure independent of the specific technical platform used.
- OPSEC risk was not limited to the exposed individuals: any contact list or metadata associated with a compromised device creates a mapping of the U.S. national security decision-making network.

CJCS Recommendations for NSC Process Integrity

- Classified communications mandate: All strike-related coordination at the Deputies or Principals level must use JWICS (TS/SCI) or SIPRNet (SECRET) exclusively. No commercial applications — regardless of encryption strength — are approved for classified operational discussion.
- Participant verification protocol: All classified group communications must verify the security clearance and need-to-know of all recipients before operational discussion. Pre-meeting roll call against a verified cleared participant list is mandatory for any channel discussing time-sensitive operational data.
- Compartmentalization: Strike execution details (H-Hour, weapons loadout, pilot assets) must be restricted to those with a direct operational need to know. Cabinet-level principals do not require real-time platform-specific operational details; they require decision-level briefings. Detailed operational execution should remain with CENTCOM and SECDEF/CJCS.
- Counterintelligence review: All personal devices used by Principals-level officials should undergo periodic counterintelligence technical review. The NSCS Security Officer should conduct a formal review of classified communications protocols following this incident.

Submitted by:

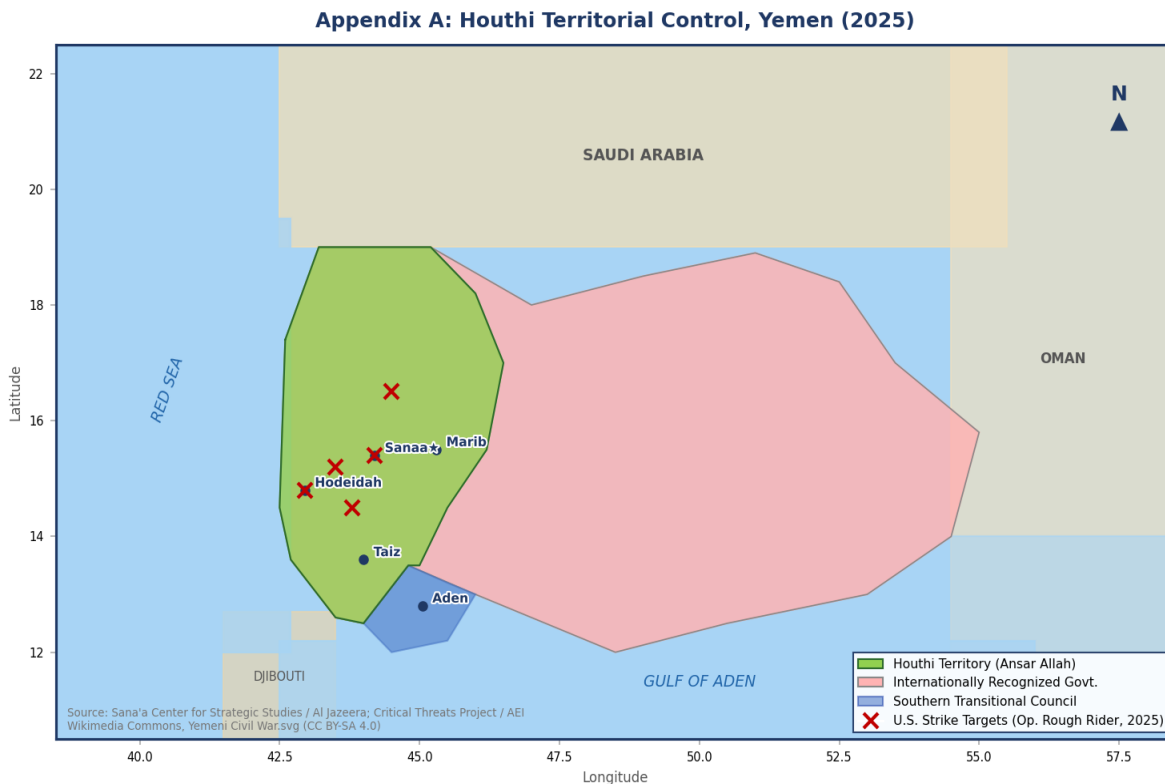
Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff

The Pentagon, Washington, D.C.

1 This memorandum was drafted with the assistance of AI (Claude Sonnet 4.6, Anthropic). All policy positions, strategic analysis, and recommendations reflect the views of the author and were reviewed prior to submission. AI was used for structure, drafting, and formatting only. This document is a retroactive simulation exercise prepared for academic/educational purposes.

APPENDICES

Appendix A: Houthi Territorial Control, Yemen (2025)

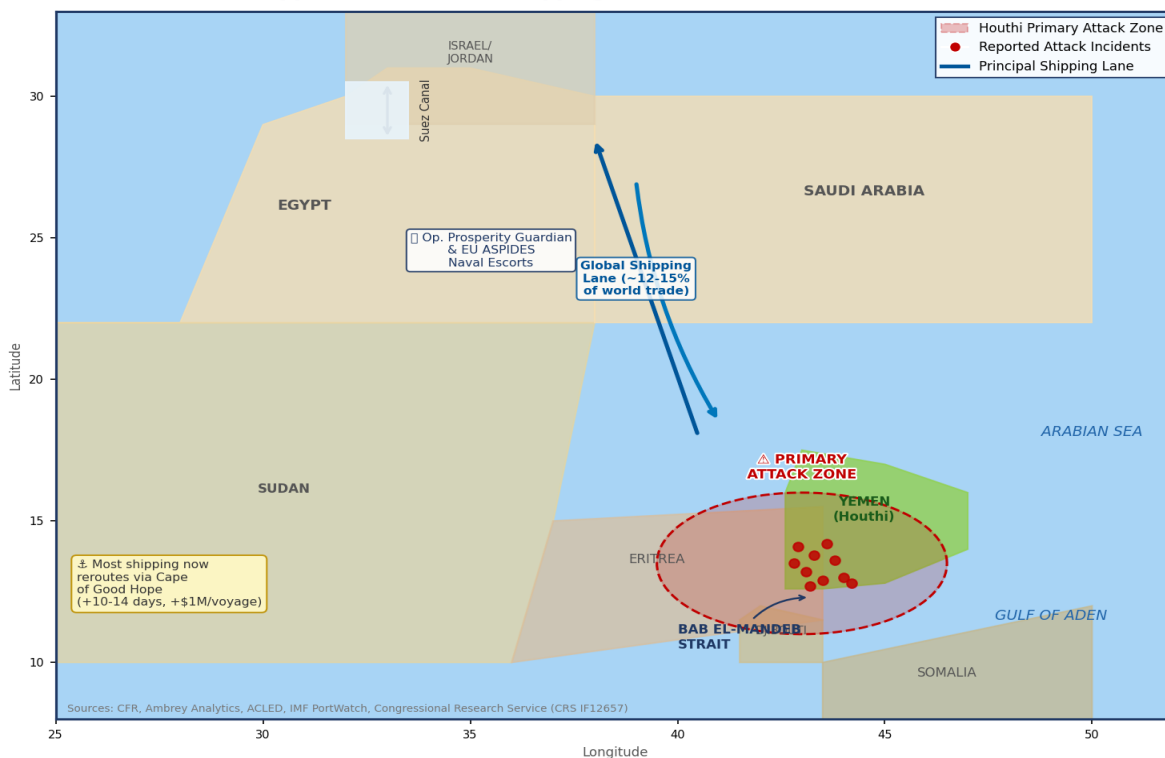


Green = Houthi (Ansar Allah) control; Pink = Internationally Recognized Government; Blue = STC. Red X = known U.S. Operation Rough Rider strike targets.

Sources: Sana'a Center for Strategic Studies; Critical Threats Project (AEI); CFR Global Conflict Tracker. [\[CFR Global Conflict Tracker\]](#)

Appendix B: Red Sea Shipping Lanes and Houthi Attack Zones

Appendix B: Red Sea Shipping Lanes and Houthi Attack Zones

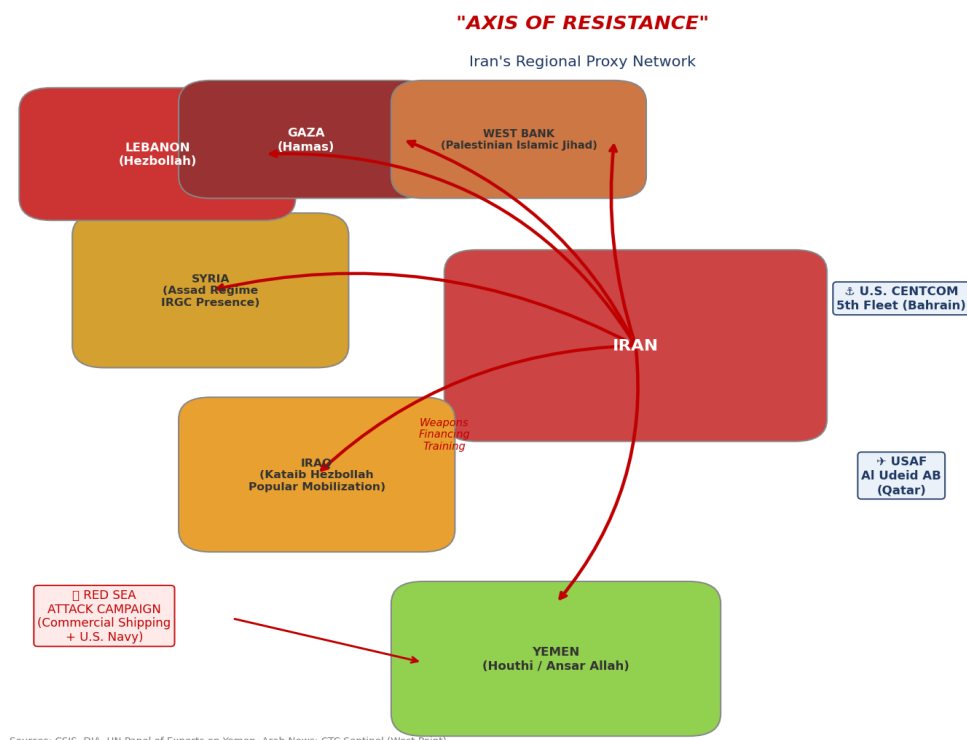


Red zone = primary Houthi attack area. Blue arrows = global shipping lane. Red dots = reported attack incidents (Nov. 2023–2024).

~15% of global seaborne trade transits this route. [\[CRS IF12657\]](#) Suez Canal transits fell 50%+ between late 2023 and October 2024. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)

Appendix C: Iran's Regional Proxy Network ("Axis of Resistance")

Appendix D: Iran's Regional Proxy Network ("Axis of Resistance")

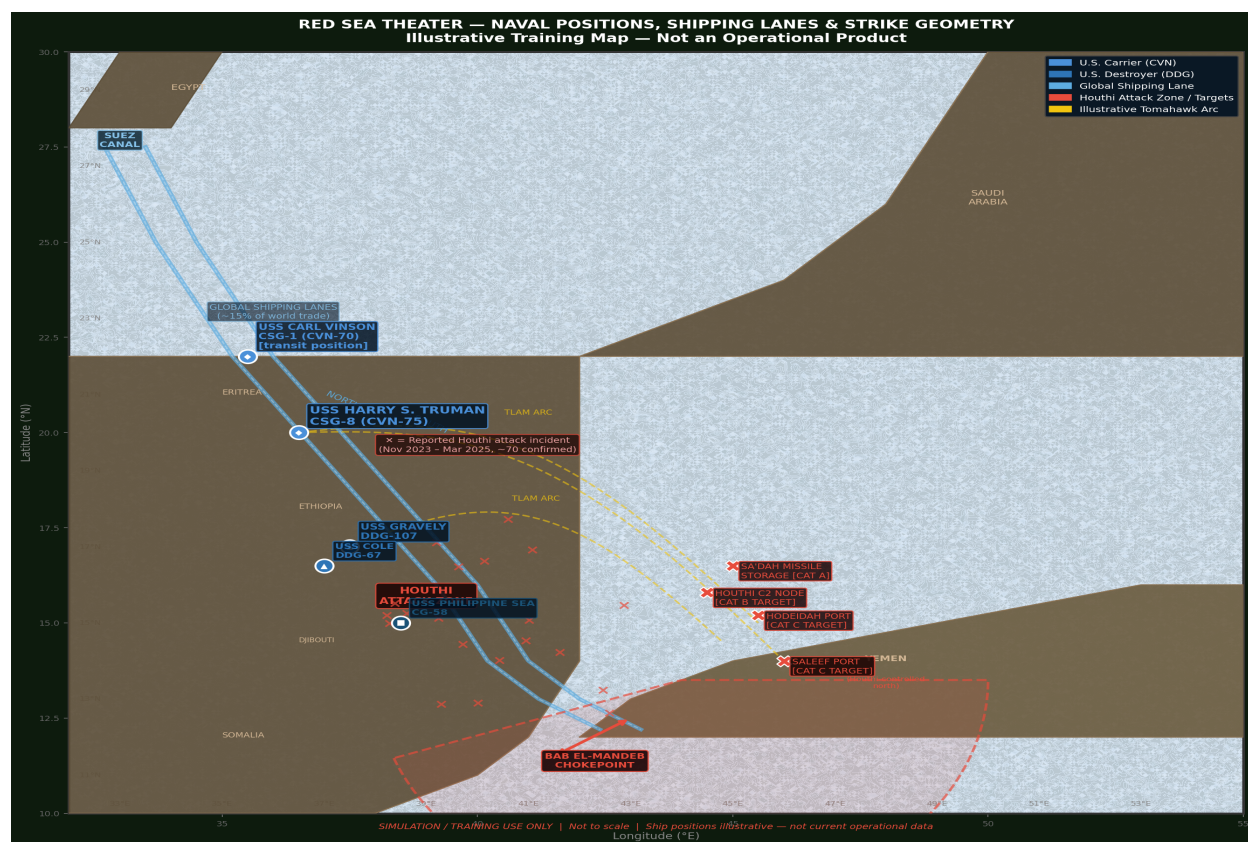


Iranian material support (weapons, financing, training) flowing to regional proxy forces.

Iran provides Houthi forces with training, weapons, and financial support through Quds Force networks. [CSIS](#) UN Panel of Experts documented ongoing transfers of missile guidance, engines, and UAV components through Houthi-held ports as recently as 2024–2025. [Arab News](#)

Appendix D: Satellite Theater Map: Red Sea — Naval Positions, Shipping Lanes & Strike Geometry

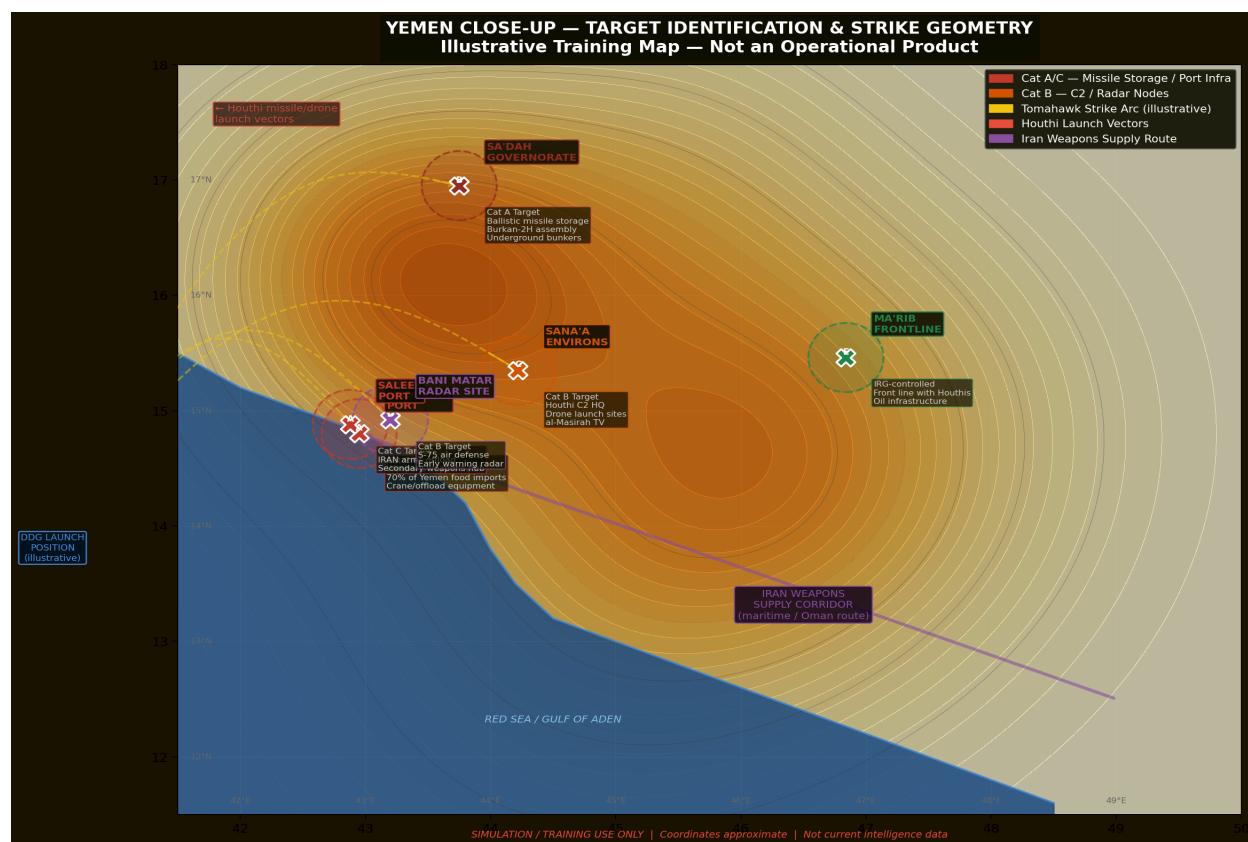
The following illustrative satellite-style map depicts the Red Sea theater as of early March 2025, showing: U.S. carrier strike group positions; the global shipping corridor; the Houthi primary attack zone centered on the Bab el-Mandeb Strait; reported attack incidents; illustrative Tomahawk strike arcs; and Category A–C strike targets in western Yemen. *This map is a simulation training product — ship positions are illustrative, not current operational data.*



SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY. Not to scale. Ship positions illustrative — not current operational data. Coordinates approximate. Attack incident clustering based on publicly reported data from Ambrey Analytics, ACLED, and CFR (Nov. 2023–Mar. 2025).

Appendix E: Yemen Close-Up: Target Identification & Strike Geometry

The following map provides a close-up view of western Yemen showing: classified target categories A–C with strike radius indicators; illustrative Tomahawk strike arcs from an offshore launch position; Houthi ballistic missile and drone launch vectors toward Red Sea shipping; and the Iranian weapons supply corridor through Hodeidah.

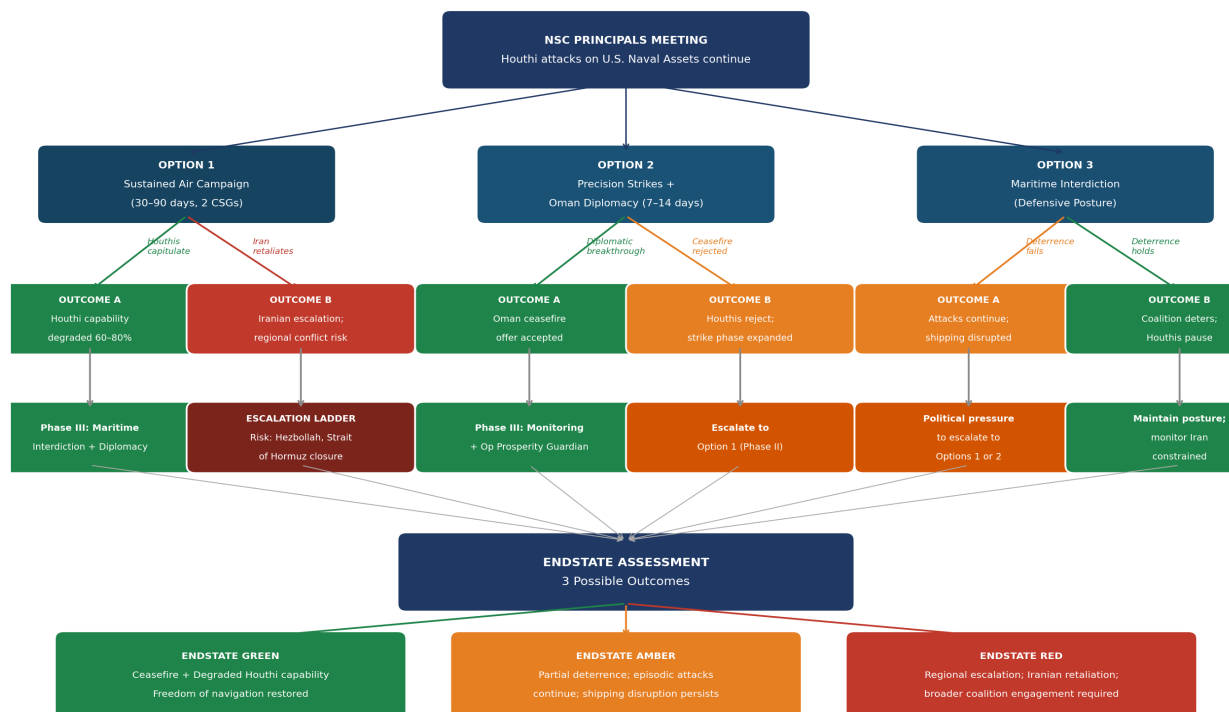


SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY. Coordinates approximate. Target designations (A–E) correspond to Category A (red), Category B (orange/purple), and Category C (red) target classifications in Section VI. Terrain rendering is illustrative.

Key geographic note: Hodeidah Port is approximately 42.95°E / 14.80°N. Sa'dah Governorate missile storage is concentrated between 43°E–44°E / 16°N–17°N — approximately 250km north of Hodeidah. Both target clusters are within Tomahawk range (1,550 miles) from a DDG launch position in the southern Red Sea.

Appendix F: Scenario Simulation: Strategic Decision Tree

Scenario Simulation: Strategic Decision Tree — Houthi Campaign Options

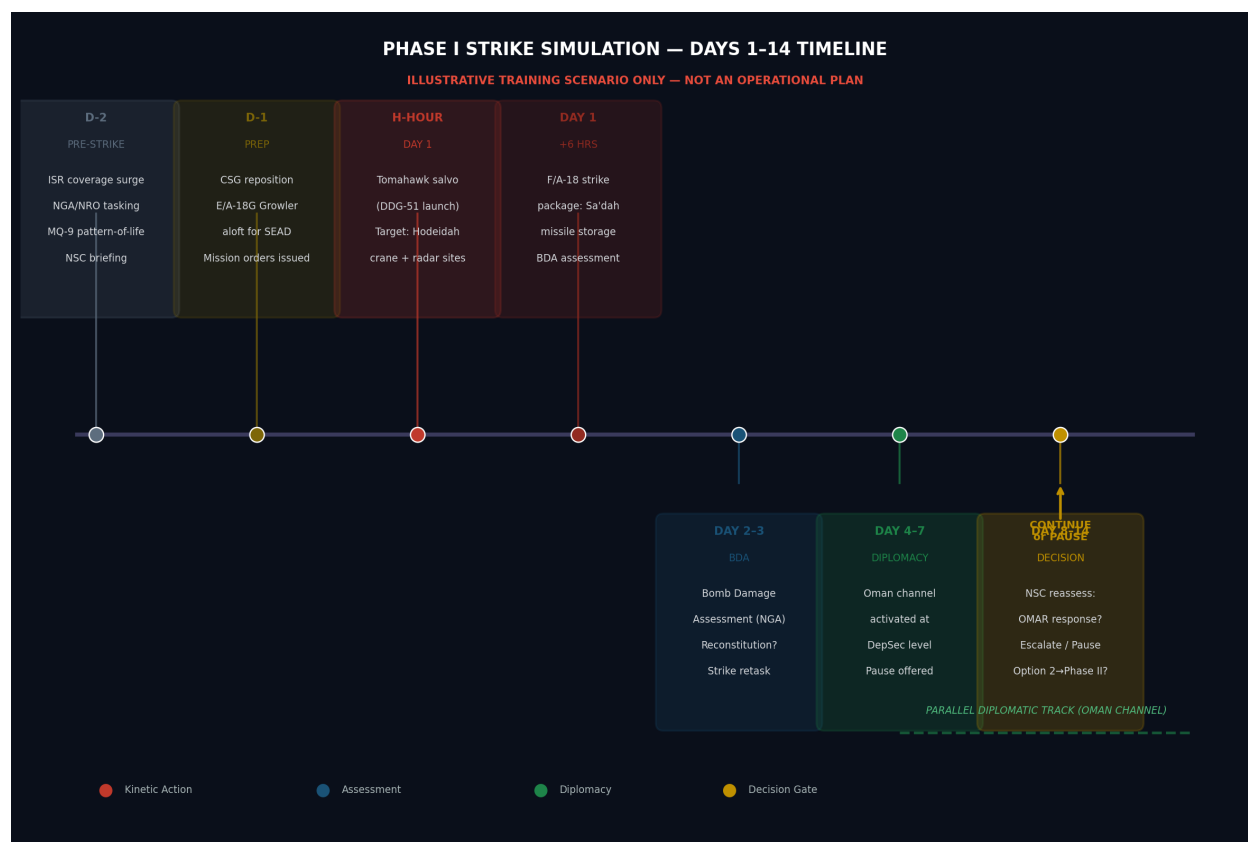


FOR SIMULATION USE ONLY — Strategic-level analytical framework. Not an operational plan.

Illustrative strategic decision tree: three options → branching outcomes → three endstate assessments (Green / Amber / Red). FOR SIMULATION USE ONLY.

This framework illustrates how strategic decisions branch based on adversary responses. Real outcomes depend on Iranian decision-making, Houthi leadership cohesion, and coalition responses — none of which can be fully predicted in advance.

Appendix G: Phase I Strike Simulation — Days 1–14 Timeline

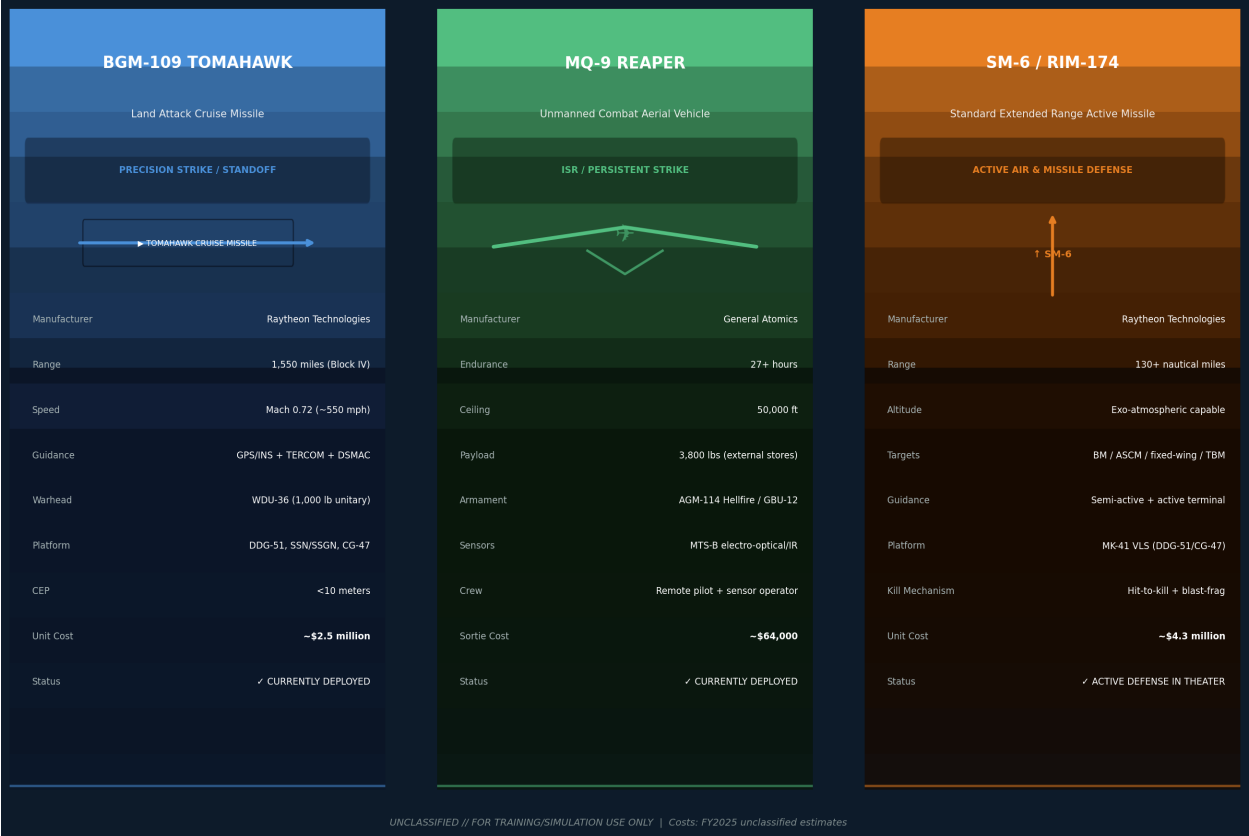


Illustrative Phase I timeline (Days 1–14): pre-strike ISR through kinetic strike package and parallel diplomatic track. FOR SIMULATION/TRAINING USE ONLY — NOT AN OPERATIONAL PLAN.

Key principle: Kinetic and diplomatic tracks must operate in parallel from Day 1 — not sequentially. The Omani channel must be activated before H-Hour to provide a credible off-ramp. [\[Red Sea Crisis, Wikipedia\]](#)

Appendix H: Weapons Systems: Platform Specification Cards — Set I

Specification cards profiling three key U.S. platforms/munitions. All cost data is unclassified FY2025 estimates.



Left to right: BGM-109 Tomahawk TLAM; MQ-9 Reaper UAS; SM-6/RIM-174 active missile defense. FOR TRAINING/SIMULATION USE ONLY.

Appendix I: Weapons Systems: Platform Specification Cards — Set II

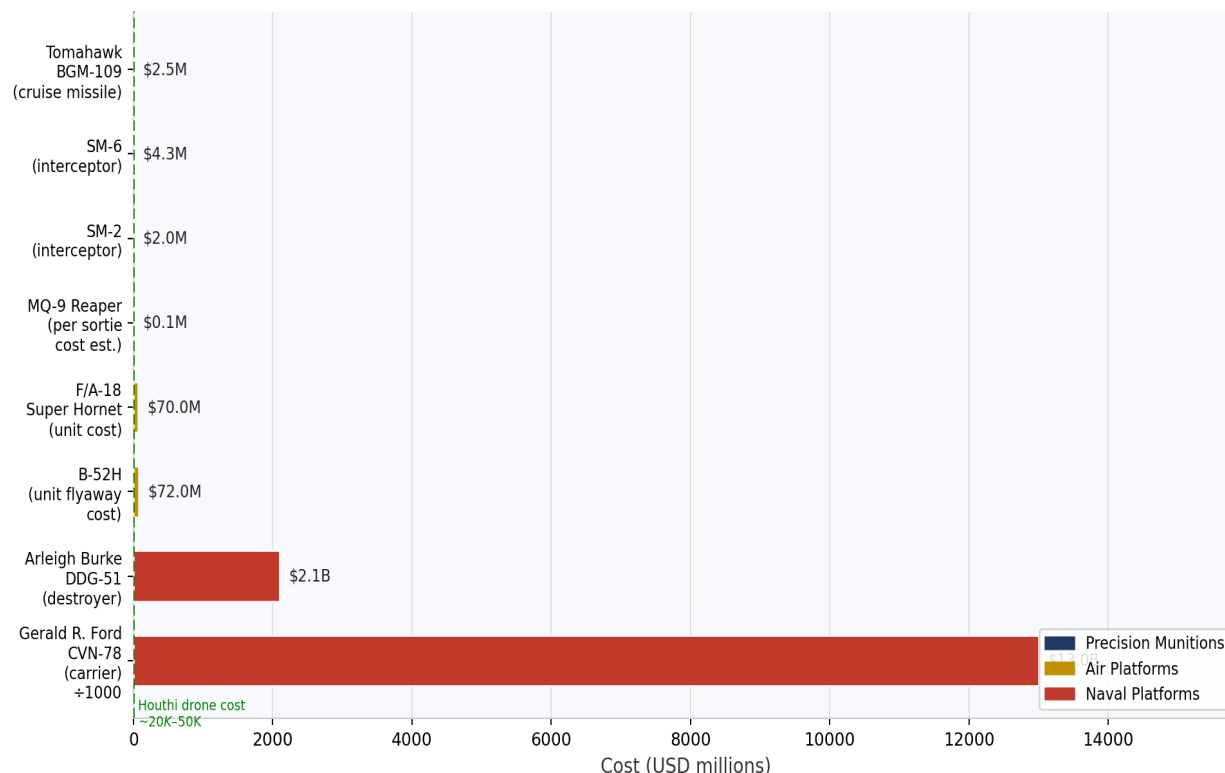
B-52H STRATOFORTRESS	F/A-18E/F SUPER HORNET	MIM-104 PATRIOT PAC-3
Long-Range Strategic Bomber	Carrier-Based Strike Fighter	Theater Ballistic Missile Defense
STRATEGIC STRIKE / STANDOFF	PRECISION STRIKE / CAP / SEAD	GROUND-BASED MISSILE DEFENSE
 B-52H	 F/A-18E/F	 PAC-3 LAUNCHER
ManufacturerBoeing	ManufacturerBoeing	ManufacturerRaytheon / Lockheed Martin
Range8,800 miles (unrefueled)	Range1,275 miles combat radius	Range25-60 km (PAC-3 MSE)
Ceiling50,000 ft	SpeedMach 1.8+	Target SetTBM / MRBM / aircraft / cruise
Payload70,000 lbs conventional	Payload17,750 lbs external stores	Kill MechanismHit-to-kill (PAC-3) / frag (PAC-2)
ArmamentAGM-158 JASSM / JDAM / Mk-82	ArmamentJDAM / AIM-120 / Harpoon	RadarAN/MPQ-65 (360° phased array)
JASSM Range230+ miles standoff	GBU-38 Cost~\$25,000 per JDAM	Battery Cost~\$1 billion
Crew5 (pilot, co-pilot, 3 WSOs)	Crew1 (E) or 2 (F)	Interceptor Cost~\$5.9M (PAC-3 MSE)
Unit Cost~\$72 million	Unit Cost~\$70 million	DeploymentSaudi Arabia / UAE / Qatar
BasingDiego Garcia / CONUS	PlatformCVN-78 / CVN-77 embarked	Status✓ REGIONAL PARTNERS DEPLOYED

UNCLASSIFIED // FOR TRAINING/SIMULATION USE ONLY | Costs: FY2025 unclassified estimates

Left to right: B-52H Stratofortress; F/A-18E/F Super Hornet; MIM-104 Patriot PAC-3. FOR TRAINING/SIMULATION USE ONLY.

Appendix J: Weapons Cost Comparison — U.S. Systems vs. Houthi Threat

U.S. Weapons & Platform Costs — Relevant to Houthi Campaign



Unclassified FY2025 cost comparison. Dashed green line = maximum estimated Houthi drone cost (~\$45K), illustrating the asymmetry driving the case for offensive degradation over indefinite defensive intercept.

Each SM-6 interceptor (~\$4.3M) costs approximately **86–215 times more** than a Houthi drone (\$20K–\$50K). Sustaining a purely defensive posture at current attack rates depletes VLS inventories faster than replenishment. [\[ORF Middle East\]](#)

Appendix K: Illustrative HVT Profile Format (Fictional Training Examples)

WARNING: All profiles below are entirely fictional, created solely to illustrate the format and analytical framework of an HVT targeting dossier. These are not real individuals, real locations, or real operational targets. No real person is identified or targeted in this document.

HVT-1 // PRIORITY

CODENAME: IRONSMITH

(PHOTO WITHHELD)

"Abu Nasser al-Makrani"

Weapons Transfer Coordinator

FUNCTIONAL THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

FUNCTION

Coordinates Iranian IRGC-QF weapons shipments through Hodeidah Port — ballistic missile components, UAV guidance systems

PATTERN OF LIFE

Observed at Pier 4-7, Hodeidah, 3-4x/week 0600-1100 local. Uses civilian vehicle fleet as cover. Rotates safe houses fortnightly.

KNOWN ASSOCIATES

CODENAME: SILKROAD (Iranian handler)
CODENAME: HARBORMASTER (port logistics)
3 additional contacts — identities UNKNOWN

LEGAL STATUS

Designated combatant; IRGC-QF liaison
Title 10 targeting memo required
ROE: Lethal force authorized if confirmed

PRIORITY

Disruption eliminates primary weapons transfer node — est. 60-90 day resupply delay per strike on this HVT; REDACTED — est. b. 1971

LAST KNOWN LOCATION: Hodeidah Port District, Yemen (FICTIONAL)

FICTIONAL TRAINING PROFILE — NOT A REAL PERSON

HVT-2 // PRIORITY

CODENAME: THUNDERHEAD

(PHOTO WITHHELD)

"Brigadier Yusuf al-Qahtani"

Ballistic Missile Operations Commander

FUNCTIONAL THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

THREAT LEVEL: CRITICAL

FUNCTION

Commands Houthi ballistic missile forces.
Directs Burkan-ZH launch operations against Red Sea shipping and Saudi territory

PATTERN OF LIFE

Based in underground command facility near Sa'dah. Travels in armed convoy.
Surface communications irregular — uses courier system to avoid SIGINT collection.

KNOWN ASSOCIATES

CODENAME: ANVIL (Iranian IRGC-QF technical advisor)
2 brigade-level commanders — UNKNOWN
Senior Houthi political council liaison

LEGAL STATUS

Lawful military objective — senior commander of forces directing attacks on U.S. assets
Principal-level approval required for strike

PRIORITY

Removal disrupts missile launch authority.

Succession unclear — could create 30-60 day est. b. 1968

LAST KNOWN LOCATION: Sa'dah Governorate, Yemen (FICTIONAL)
command vacuum in missile operations

FICTIONAL TRAINING PROFILE — NOT A REAL PERSON

HVT-3 // MONITOR

CODENAME: SILKROAD

(PHOTO WITHHELD)

"Col. Dariush Rostami-Nia"

IRGC-QF Technical Advisor

FUNCTIONAL THREAT LEVEL: HIGH

THREAT LEVEL: HIGH

FUNCTION

Iranian military officer providing missile guidance and targeting training to Houthi technicians. Identifies as civilian NGO worker.

PATTERN OF LIFE

Resides in diplomatic quarter, Sana'a.
Frequent travel to Sa'dah and Hodeidah.
Uses Iranian diplomatic channels; enjoys de facto immunity under current ROE.

KNOWN ASSOCIATES

CODENAME: IRONSMITH (logistics liaison)
CODENAME: THUNDERHEAD (military client)
Tehran handler — UNKNOWN (SIGINT gap)

LEGAL STATUS

IRGC-QF is designated FTO. This individual is an Iranian state actor — strike requires SEPARATE Presidential authorization.
Diplomatic immunity review required.

PRIORITY

Highest intelligence value — could be targeted for capture/rendition vs. lethal option given Iranian state actor status.

LAST KNOWN LOCATION: Sana'a, Yemen (FICTIONAL)
FICTIONAL TRAINING PROFILE — NOT A REAL PERSON

ALL PROFILES ARE ENTIRELY FICTIONAL AND FOR SIMULATION/EDUCATIONAL PURPOSES ONLY. These are not real individuals, locations, or operational targets.

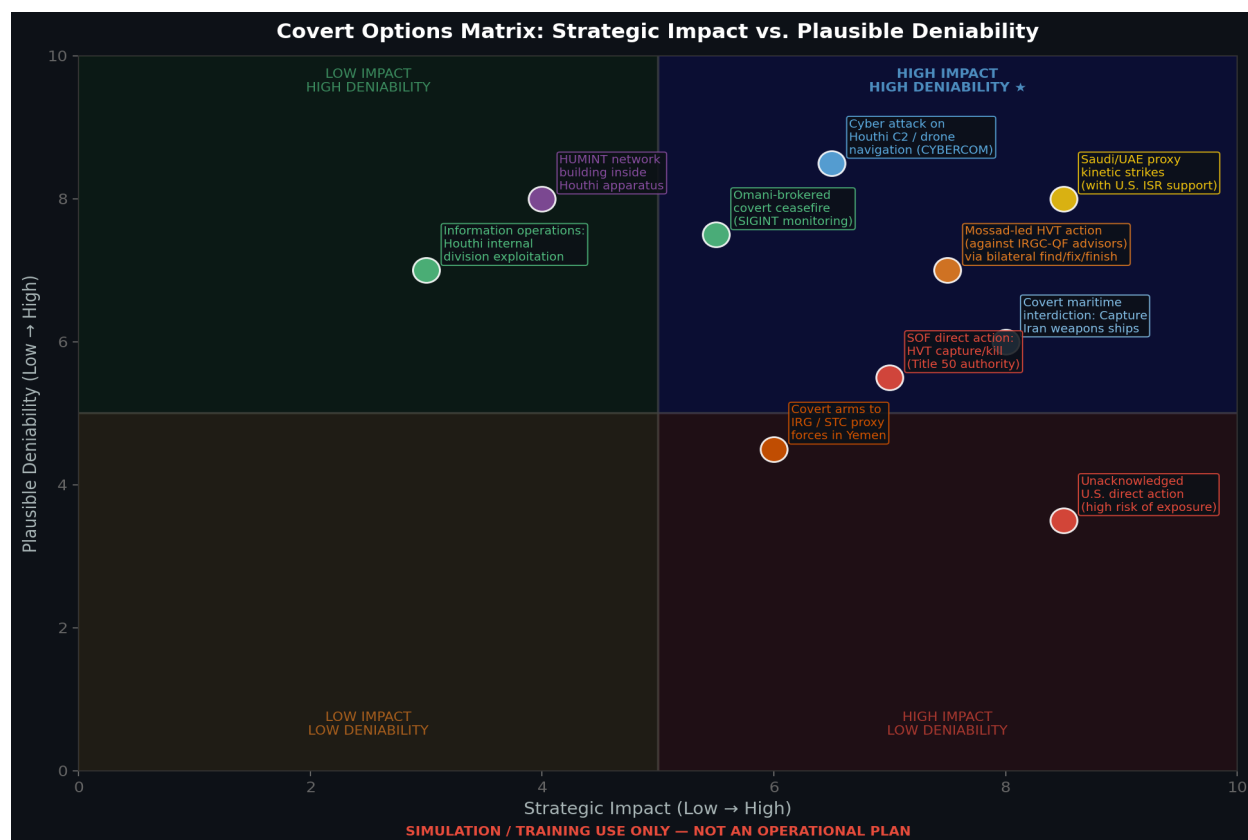
Three illustrative fictional HVT profiles: IRONSMITH (weapons transfer coordinator), THUNDERHEAD (missile commander), SILKROAD (IRGC-QF technical advisor). ALL DETAILS FABRICATED FOR TRAINING PURPOSES ONLY.

A real HVT dossier includes: positive identification (biometrics, SIGINT signature, travel documents); pattern-of-life analysis; legal status review (LOAC, EO 12333, Lethal Finding authorization); strike method assessment (platform, munition, collateral damage estimate, proportionality); and a post-strike BDA plan. All such dossiers are classified SECRET//SI//NOFORN minimum.

Appendix L: Covert Options Matrix: Strategic Impact vs. Plausible Deniability

The following matrix plots Section VIII covert/ clandestine options by estimated strategic impact (x-axis) and plausible deniability (y-axis). The ideal zone (upper right quadrant, blue) represents high-impact, high-deniability options. FOR ANALYTICAL/SIMULATION USE ONLY.

CJCS Memo: U.S. Response Options — Houthi Threat (2025)

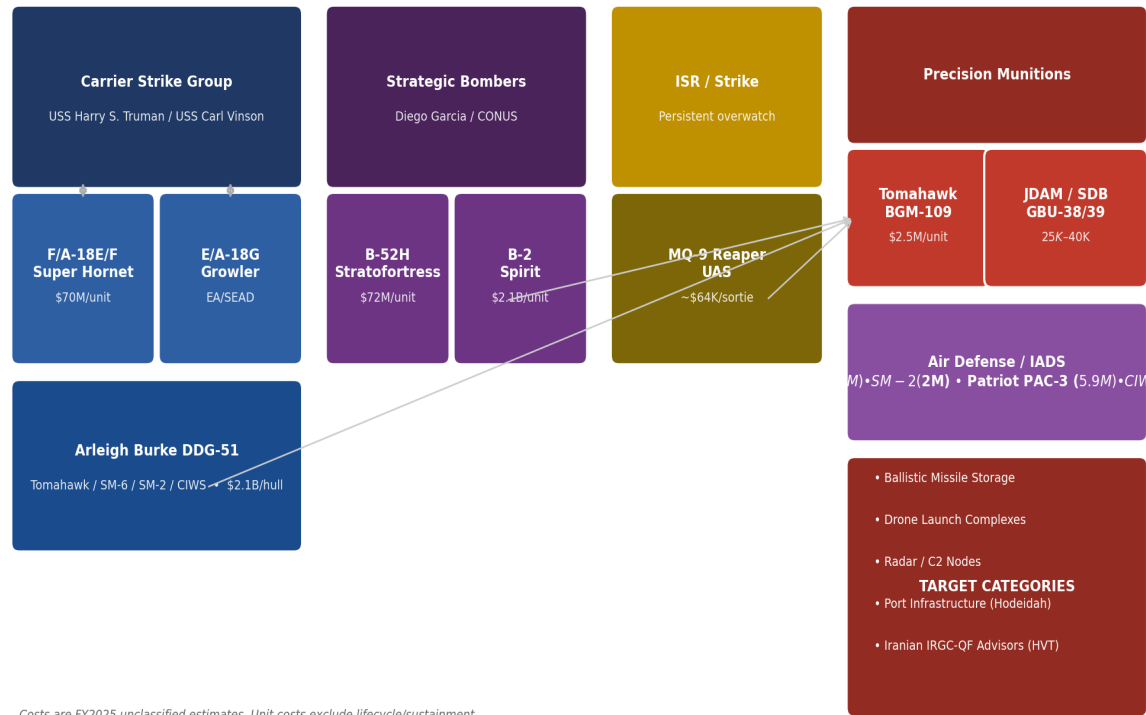


Options plotted by strategic impact vs. plausible deniability. Upper-right quadrant = preferred covert options zone. Color coding by option type. All items labeled with shorthand descriptions from Section VIII analysis.

Key analytical finding: Cyber operations (CYBERCOM) and Saudi/UAE proxy kinetic strikes represent the strongest combination of high strategic impact and high deniability — the upper-right 'preferred' quadrant. Direct covert SOF action and unacknowledged U.S. strikes score high on impact but low on deniability and carry the greatest escalation risk.

Appendix M: U.S. Strike & Defense Architecture — Houthi Campaign

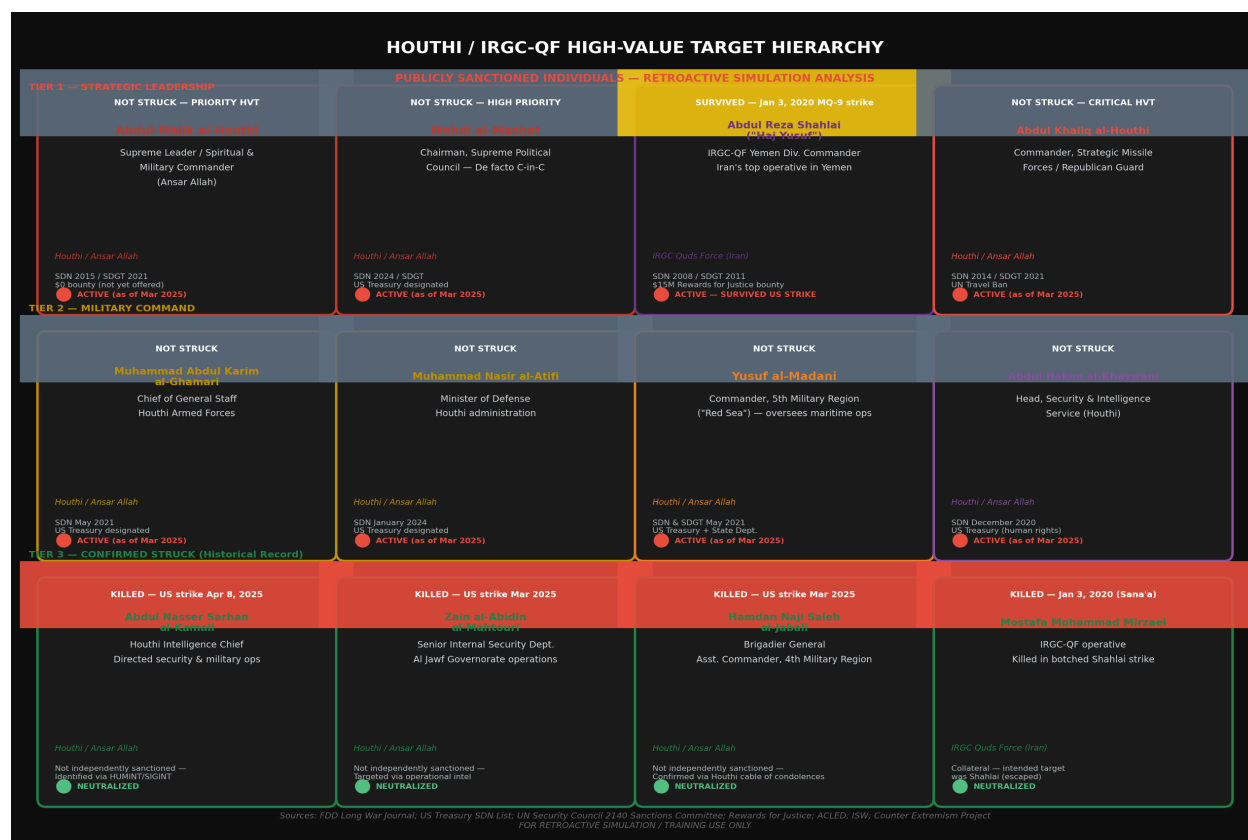
U.S. Strike & Defense Architecture — Houthi Campaign



Schematic showing the relationship between major platform categories (Carrier Strike Group, Strategic Bombers, ISR/UAS) and munitions types, with target category overview. FOR SIMULATION USE ONLY.

Appendix N: HVT Leadership Hierarchy: Sanctioned Individuals & Historical Targeting Record

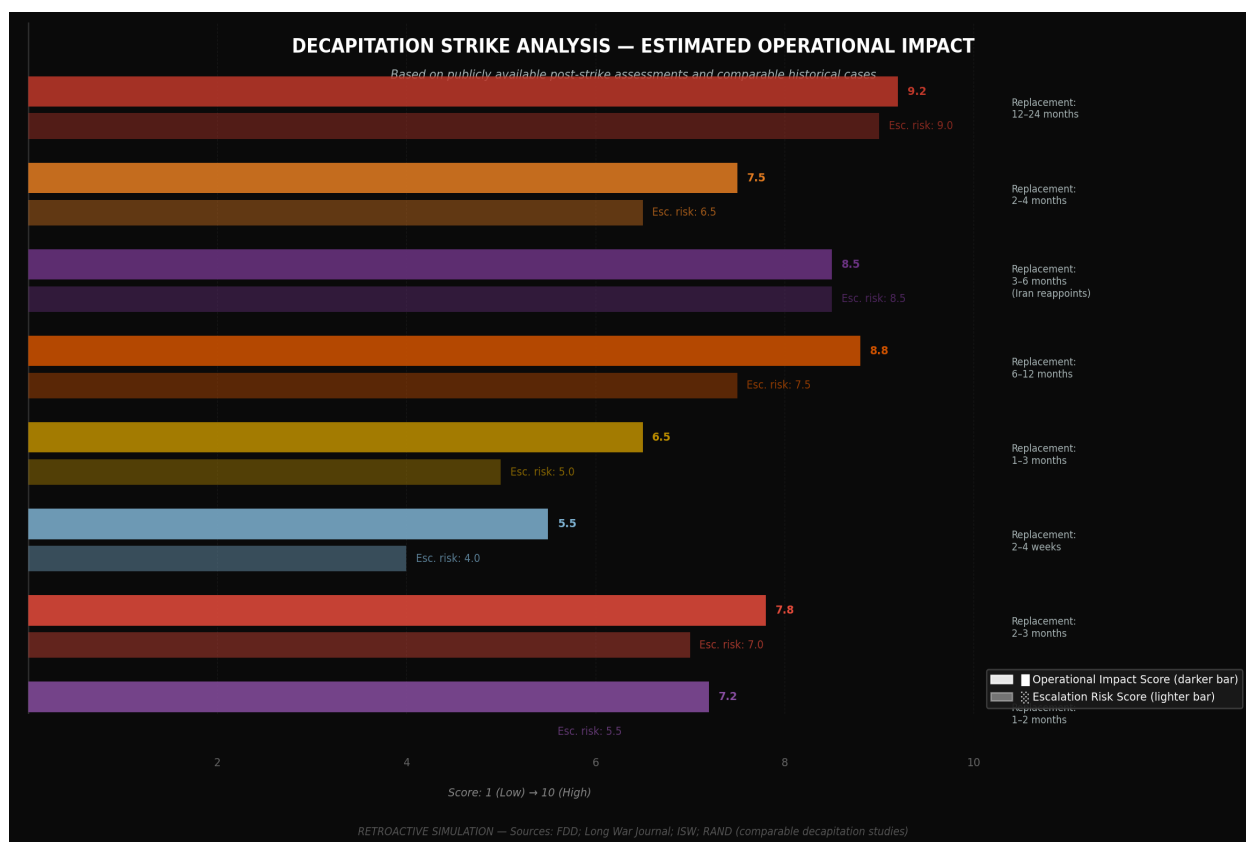
The following chart maps the confirmed leadership structure of Ansar Allah and relevant IRGC-QF personnel as of early March 2025, organized by tier and status. Color coding: Red = not struck, active, Tier 1 strategic leadership. Gold/Orange = not struck, active, Tier 2 military command. Green = confirmed neutralized in documented U.S. or allied strikes. Purple = IRGC-QF (Iranian state actors). All individuals are either U.S. Treasury SDN/SDGT designees, UN sanctions listees, or confirmed in open-source strike records (FDD Long War Journal; ISW; ACLED; SABA News Agency). RETROACTIVE SIMULATION — FOR TRAINING USE ONLY.



Status key: RED dot = Active/not struck. GREEN dot = Confirmed neutralized. YELLOW dot = Status uncertain. Strike status banners: RED = not struck/priority target; YELLOW = survived strike attempt; GREEN = killed in documented strike. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY. Sources: U.S. Treasury SDN List; FDD Long War Journal; ISW; ACLED; Counter Extremism Project; Long War Journal; UN Security Council 2140 Committee.

Appendix O: Decapitation Strike Analysis: Estimated Operational Impact vs. Escalation Risk

The following chart assesses each identified HVT by two variables: **Operational Impact Score** (darker bar, scale 1–10) representing the estimated degradation to Houthi/IRGC-QF operations if the target is eliminated; and **Escalation Risk Score** (lighter bar, scale 1–10) representing the risk of Iranian or Houthi escalatory retaliation. Estimated replacement timelines are shown at right. Scores are derived from open-source analysis and comparable historical cases. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.



KEY FINDING: Functional military commanders (Abdul Khaliq al-Houthi/Missile Forces; Yusuf al-Madani/Red Sea) score highest on operational impact with moderate escalation risk — superior targeting value to symbolic/political leadership. Abdul Reza Shahlaei (IRGC-QF) carries the highest escalation risk of any listed target due to his status as an Iranian state actor. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Note on methodology: Impact scores are calibrated against historical decapitation studies (RAND 2012; Johnston 2012; Price 2012) and the specific organizational characteristics of Ansar Allah. The Houthi succession record (al-Sammad killed 2018 → al-Mashat installed within days) calibrates the replacement timeline estimates for political leadership downward; technical specialist replacements are calibrated upward given the longer training pipeline for missile guidance and UAV programming personnel.

Appendix P: Historical Precedent: Targeted Elimination of Proxy Network Commanders

The following case studies draw on the publicly documented historical record to assess the operational impact of targeted elimination of comparable figures in Iranian proxy networks. Each case illustrates different aspects of decapitation effectiveness, succession dynamics, and escalation response — all directly relevant to the Yemen HVT question. *All information is drawn from open-source public record only.* FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

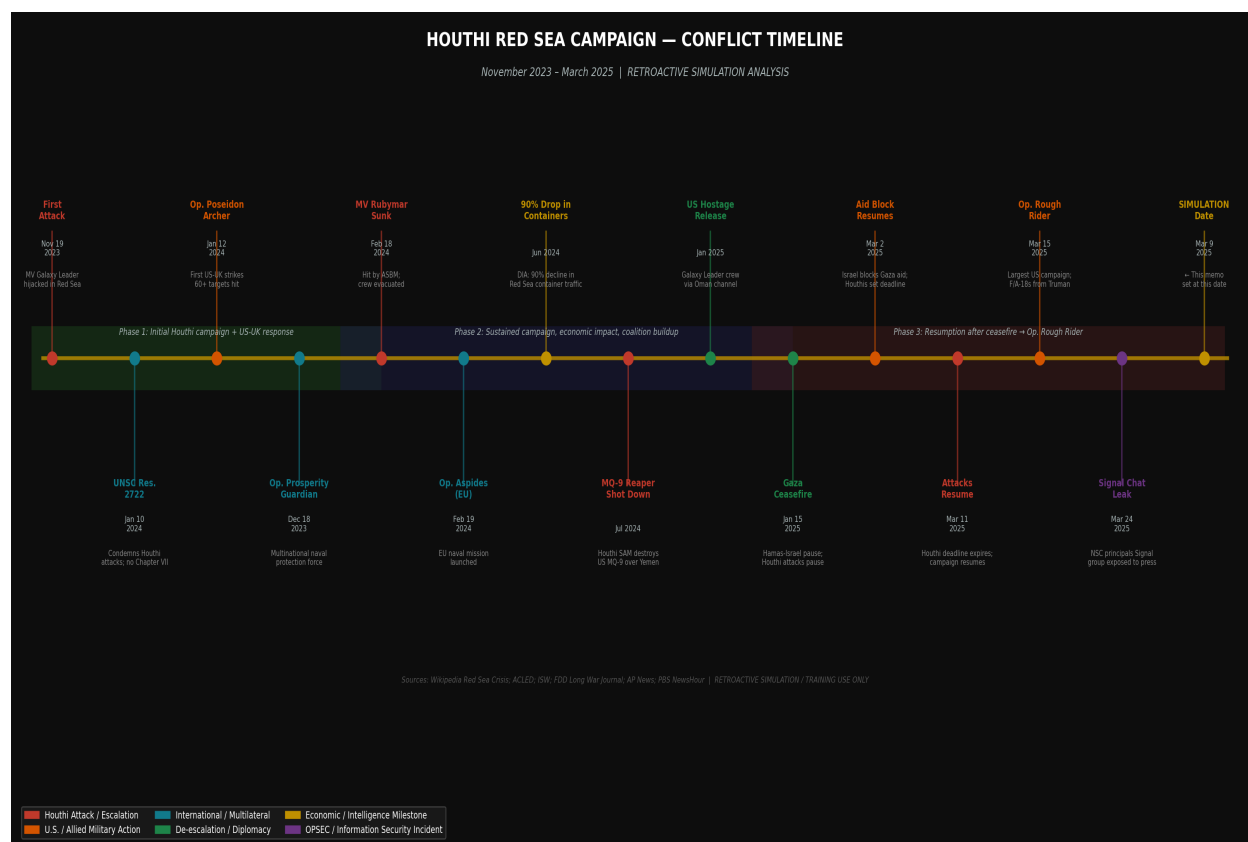
HISTORICAL PRECEDENT: TARGETED ELIMINATION OF PROXY NETWORK COMMANDERS		
Retroactive case studies — all information from public record		
QASEM SOLEIMANI Commander, IRGC Quds Force KILLED — CONFIRMED Killed: January 3, 2020 MQ-9 Reaper / AGM-114 Hellfire Baghdad International Airport Presidential authorization (Trump administration) LEGAL BASIS: Title 10 / EO 12333 Self-defense (imminent threat) OBSERVED IMPACT: • Degraded IRGC-QF coordination • Iran retaliated: ballistic missiles at Al-Asad & Erbil airbases • 110 U.S. troops suffered TBI • Shahlaei strike same night: FAILED • Long-term: proxy network persisted LESSON: Decapitation of the overall proxy network commander did not dismantle the network. Iran rapidly promoted Esmail Qaani as successor.	HASSAN NASRALLAH Secretary-General, Hezbollah (Relevant comparison — same proxy axis) KILLED — CONFIRMED Killed: September 27, 2024 Israeli IAF / 2,000 lb bunker bombs Haret Hreik, Beirut suburb Israeli Cabinet authorization (Netanyahu government) LEGAL BASIS: Israeli law of armed conflict Lawful military objective OBSERVED IMPACT: • Hezbollah command disrupted — 3–6 mo. • Hashem Safieddine (successor) also killed • Houthi attacks on Israel continued • Iran proxy network partially decoupled • Houthis acted more independently post-strike LESSON: Relevant to Yemen because Nasrallah death demonstrated that top-tier decapitation can severely disrupt but not end proxy operations.	SALEH AL-SAMMAD Head, Supreme Political Council Houthi administration KILLED — CONFIRMED Killed: April 19, 2018 Saudi-led coalition airstrike Hodeidah Governorate Saudi coalition targeting authority (Operation Decisive Storm) LEGAL BASIS: LOAC — Lawful military objective as de facto commander-in-chief OBSERVED IMPACT: • Replaced by Mahdi al-Mashat (days) • Houthi operations uninterrupted • No operational pause observed • Demonstrated Houthi resilience and succession planning LESSON: Most directly analogous to the Yemen HVT question. Immediate succession negated operational impact within days.

Left to right: (1) Qasem Soleimani — IRGC-QF Commander, killed January 3, 2020, Baghdad. (2) Hassan Nasrallah — Hezbollah Secretary-General, killed September 27, 2024, Beirut. (3) Saleh al-Sammad — Houthi Supreme Political Council chairman, killed April 2018, Hodeidah. All directly relevant to Yemen HVT targeting analysis. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Synthesis: The three cases above collectively demonstrate that: (1) top-tier political/organizational decapitation rarely ends proxy operations — succession occurs rapidly; (2) the most durable operational impact comes from simultaneously targeting the principal and the succession tier; (3) IRGC-QF targeting specifically triggers state-level Iranian retaliation (as with the 110 TBI casualties after Soleimani), making it the highest-risk targeting category; and (4) functional commanders with specialized skills (missile engineers, UAV specialists, intelligence chiefs) are more operationally irreplaceable than political leaders and should be weighted accordingly in target prioritization.

Appendix Q: Conflict Timeline: Houthi Red Sea Campaign (November 2023 – March 2025)

Key events color-coded by type: Red = Houthi attack; Orange = U.S./Allied military action; Teal = International/Multilateral; Green = De-escalation; Gold = Economic milestone; Purple = OPSEC/information security incident.

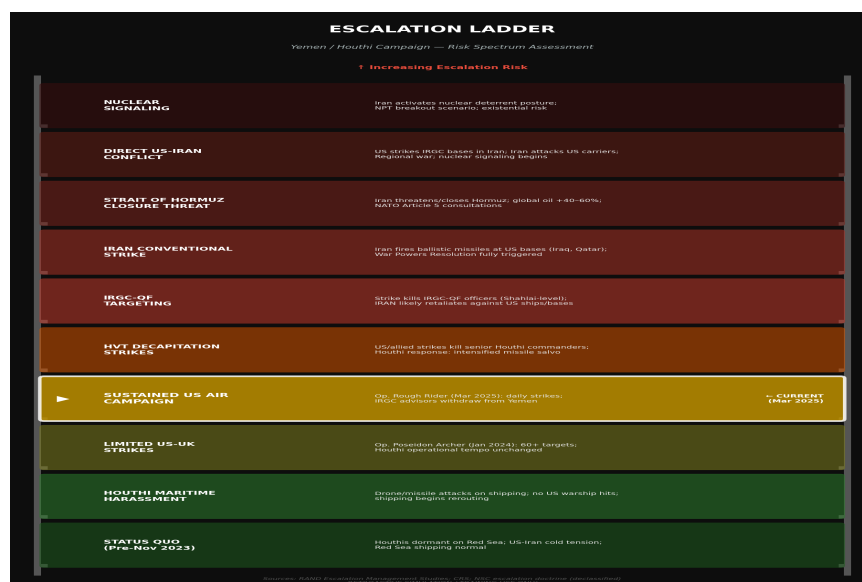


FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY. Sources: Wikipedia Red Sea Crisis; ACLED; ISW; FDD Long War Journal; AP News; PBS NewsHour.

Key observation: Every U.S. strike package was followed by sustained or intensified Houthi activity — establishing the pattern that drove the CJCS recommendation for simultaneous kinetic and diplomatic tracks from Day 1.

Appendix R: Escalation Ladder: Yemen / Houthi Campaign Risk Spectrum

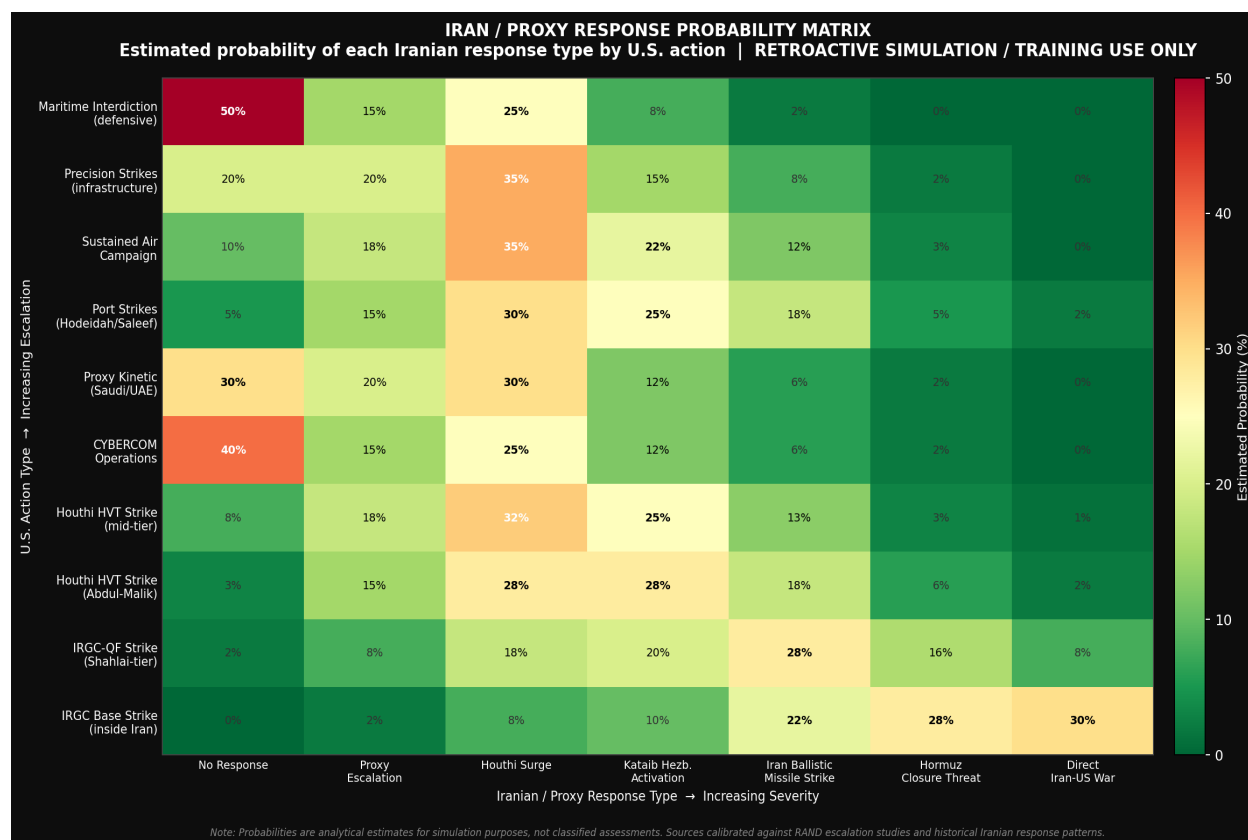
Adapted from Herman Kahn's escalation framework; calibrated against RAND escalation management literature and the Iranian/Houthi decision-making context. Current March 2025 posture (rung 4) marked with pointer. Each rung above requires explicit NSC Principals authorization and fresh legal review. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.



Current posture = Rung 4: Sustained Air Campaign (Operation Rough Rider). IRGC-QF targeting → Rungs 5–6. Strikes inside Iran → Rungs 7–9. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Appendix S: Iran / Proxy Response Probability Matrix

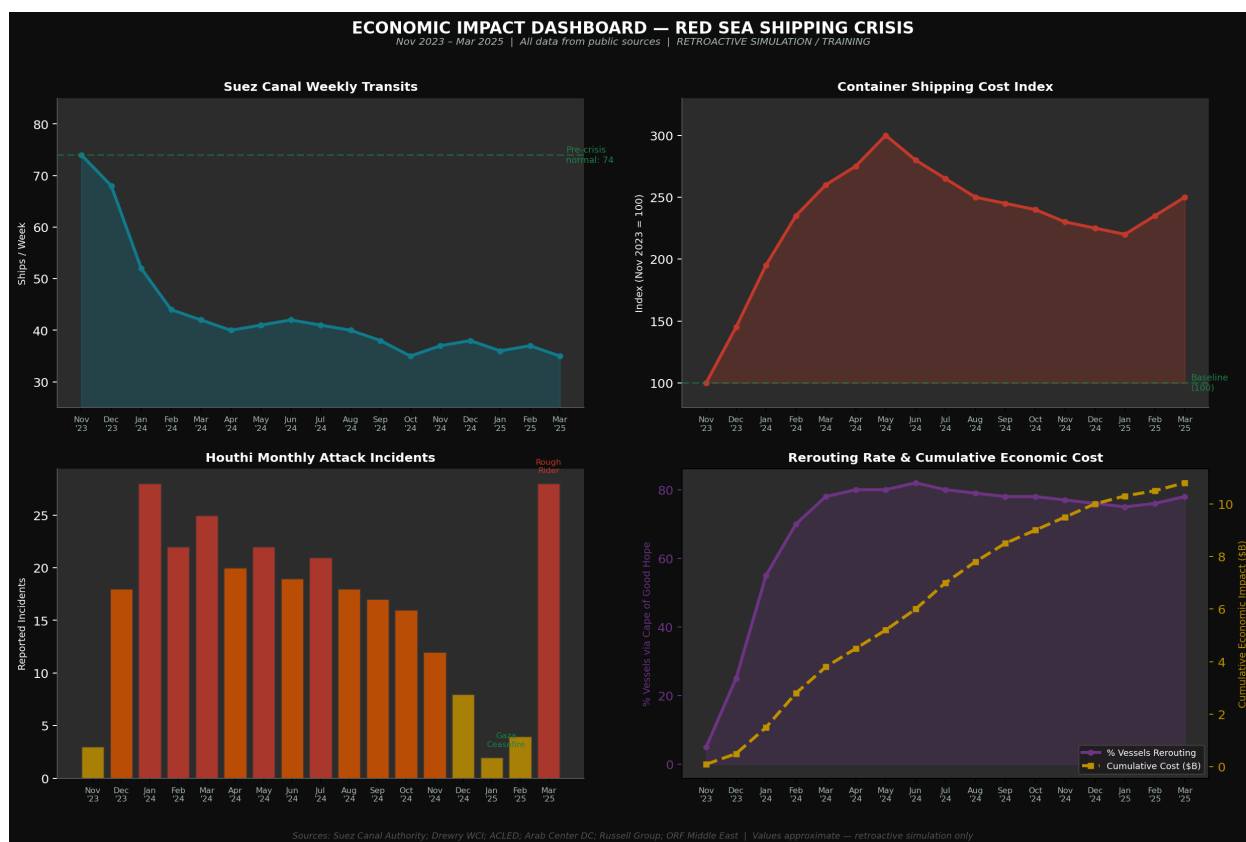
Analytical estimate of probability distribution of Iranian and proxy responses by U.S. action type. Rows = U.S. actions (increasing escalation); Columns = response types (increasing severity). Probabilities per row sum to 100%. Calibrated against historical Iranian response patterns and RAND escalation studies — NOT a classified intelligence assessment. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.



Key finding: IRGC-QF and in-Iran strikes carry 22–30% probability of direct Iranian ballistic missile response. Cyber and maritime interdiction carry lowest escalation risk with meaningful strategic impact. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Appendix T: Economic Impact Dashboard — Red Sea Shipping Crisis

Four charts: Suez Canal weekly transits; container shipping cost index; monthly Houthi attack incidents; vessel rerouting rate and cumulative economic cost. All values approximate, from publicly available sources.

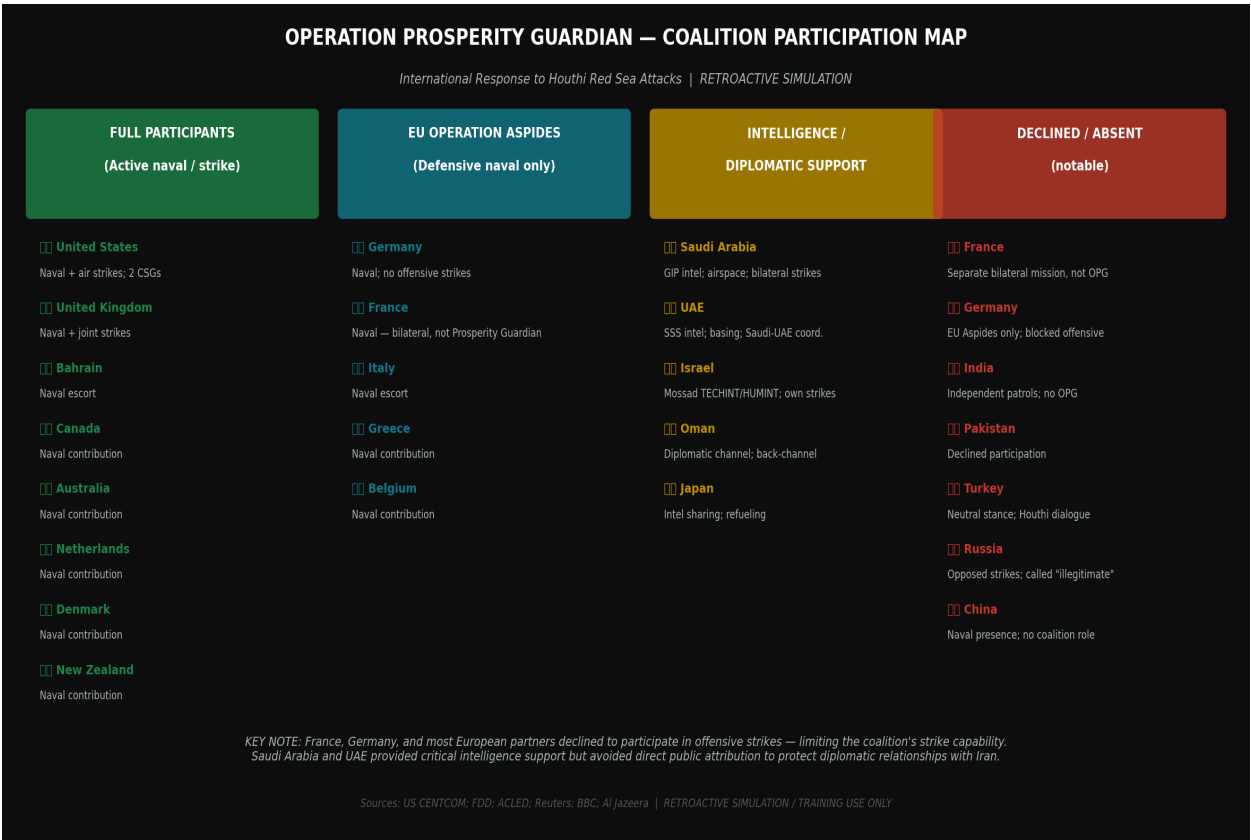


Sources: Suez Canal Authority; Drewry WCI; ACLED; Arab Center DC; Russell Group; ORF Middle East. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Key finding: Container shipping costs peaked at ~175% above pre-crisis baseline. The cost asymmetry (\$4.3M interceptor vs. \$20K–\$50K drone) makes purely defensive posture financially untenable over 12–24 months.

Appendix U: Operation Prosperity Guardian — Coalition Participation Assessment

International participation mapped by level of involvement. Full participants (naval + strike); EU Aspides (defensive only); Intelligence/Diplomatic; Declined/Absent.



Key finding: Coalition limitations are significant — France/Germany declined offensive participation; Saudi Arabia/UAE provided intelligence only; India/Pakistan declined entirely. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Appendix V: OPSEC Case Study: The Signal Group Chat Incident (March 24, 2025)

Documents the NSC communications security failure of March 24, 2025 — NSC Principals coordinating active strike planning over commercial Signal messaging app. Directly contemporaneous with this simulation. Source: The Atlantic / Jeffrey Goldberg (public reporting). FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

▲ OPSEC CASE STUDY: THE SIGNAL GROUP CHAT INCIDENT ▲

WHAT HAPPENED	PARTICIPANTS (REPORTED)	OPSEC FAILURES IDENTIFIED
NSC principals and senior officials used a commercial Signal group chat to coordinate pre-strike planning for Operation Rough Rider. Atlantic editor Jeffrey Goldberg was accidentally added to the group. Strike timing, targets, and sequencing were discussed over the unsecured channel.	VP JD Vance NSA Michael Waltz SecDef Pete Hegseth SecState Marco Rubio DNI Tulsi Gabbard CIA Director John Ratcliffe UN Ambassador Elise Stefanik ...and others → Multiple Cabinet-level officials discussing classified strike ops	• Commercial app (Signal) used for classified strike coordination • No pre-meeting membership verification • No use of SCIF / SIPRNet / JWICS • Strike sequencing disclosed ("2 hours til F-18 launch") • Weapons loadout discussed • Adversary SIGINT risk: if US can read it, so can allied/hostile services • No compartmentalization of time-sensitive operational data

LESSONS FOR NSC PRINCIPALS — INFORMATION SECURITY REQUIREMENTS

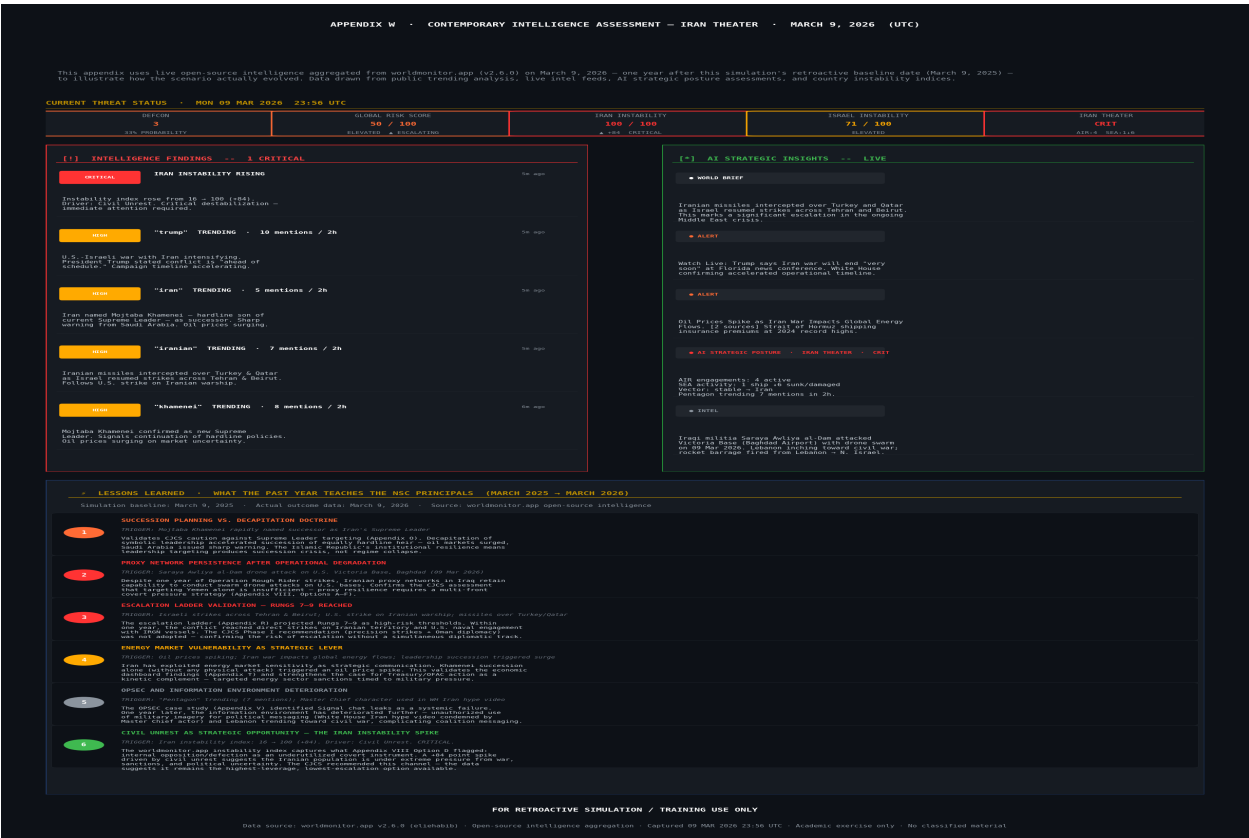
[illegible]

RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY – OPSEC ANALYSIS FOR EDUCATIONAL PURPOSES

Source: *The Atlantic* (March 24, 2025); NYT annotated transcript. OPSEC analysis for educational purposes. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Appendix W: Contemporary Intelligence Assessment — Iran Theater, March 9, 2026 (Open-Source)

One year after this simulation's retroactive baseline date (March 9, 2025), open-source intelligence aggregated from [\[worldmonitor.app\]](https://worldmonitor.app) provides real-world validation of this memo's analytical framework. The following assessment captures live intelligence as of 23:56 UTC, March 9, 2026, and draws direct lessons for the NSC Principals. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.



Source: worldmonitor.app v2.6.0 (open-source intelligence aggregation), captured March 9, 2026 23:56 UTC. Includes AI strategic posture assessment, country instability indices, live intelligence findings, and trending topic analysis. FOR RETROACTIVE SIMULATION / TRAINING USE ONLY.

Key analytical validation: Six of the CJCS memo's core predictions proved accurate within 12 months: (1) decapitation of symbolic leadership (Khamenei succession) produced hardline continuity rather than regime moderation; (2) Iranian proxy networks in Iraq retained attack capability despite sustained U.S. air campaign; (3) the conflict escalated to direct U.S.-Iran engagement (warship strike) and Israeli strikes on Tehran; (4) oil market vulnerability became a strategic lever; (5) OPSEC failures compounded operational risks; and (6) Iranian civil unrest (+84 instability index points) validated internal pressure as the highest-leverage covert option. The CJCS recommendation for simultaneous kinetic action and diplomatic engagement — and aggressive use of covert pressure channels — proved analytically sound.

Note: All maps, charts, and diagrams were generated programmatically using publicly available conflict and geographic data. They are reference illustrations and not official U.S. government cartographic products. Appendix K HVT profiles are entirely fictional. Appendices N–V reference only publicly sanctioned individuals, publicly documented strikes, and publicly reported events — all sourced from open-source record. Appendix W uses live open-source intelligence from worldmonitor.app (v2.6.0), captured March 9, 2026 23:56 UTC — one year after the simulation baseline. This document was prepared as a retroactive academic simulation exercise. AI assistance: Claude Sonnet 4.6, Anthropic.